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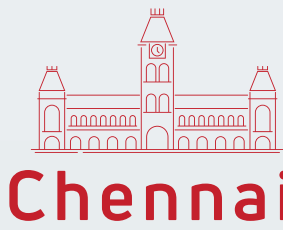
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LEFT WING EXTREMISM
India is now free from Maoists, declares Shah
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Rupee 'doing fine', says FM as value hits further lows
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Russia 'pleased' as oil ship reaches ally Cuba
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China's massive head start over India in EVs
Early adoption reduced its exposure to fuel crisis
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ROYAL SHOW
Burger proves too hot to handle for CSK
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NEARBY



Sentencing in Sattankulam case posted for April 2

MADURAI
The First Additional District and Sessions Court in Madurai on Monday posted the Sattankulam custodial deaths case of trader P. Jayaraj, 58, and his son J. Benicks, 31, for sentencing to April 2. All nine police personnel were convicted on March 23. » **PAGE 6**

CPI(M) names candidates for 5 constituencies

CHENNAI
The State unit of the Communist Party of India (Marxist) on Monday announced its candidates for five Assembly constituencies for April 23 polls. » **PAGE 6**

Trump threatens Iran's oil, power sites over deal

U.S. President claims to have made 'great progress' with 'more reasonable regime' in Iran; Tehran says it is not engaged in direct talks, terms proposals received through intermediaries 'irrational'

Stanly Johny

U.S. President Donald Trump said on Monday that his administration was engaging in talks with Iran and threatened to strike its oil, power and water infrastructure if Tehran did not quickly agree to a deal and reopen the Strait of Hormuz.

Iran denied holding direct talks, saying it had received a proposal through intermediaries that contained "very excessive, unrealistic and irrational" demands.

"The United States of America is in serious discussions with a new and more reasonable regime to end our Military Operations in Iran," Mr. Trump wrote in a social media post. "Great progress has



Collateral damage: Fire breaks out at an Israeli oil refinery after being hit by debris from an intercepted Iranian missile. REUTERS

been made but, if for any reason a deal is not shortly reached, which it probably will be, and if the Hormuz Strait is not immediately "Open for Business," we will conclude our lovely "stay" in Iran by blowing up and completely obliterate

all of their Electric[ity] Generating Plants, Oil Wells and Kharg Island (and possibly all desalinization plants!)."

48-hour deadline
On March 10, Mr. Trump had threatened to hit Iran

"20 times harder" if it did not open the Strait of Hormuz. On March 21, he gave a 48-hour deadline to Iran to reopen the strait, threatening to destroy Iran's power plants if it did not do so. On March 23, Mr. Trump backed off, delaying his deadline by five days, which was extended to April 6.

Iran and Israel continued to exchange fire on Monday. While the Israel Defence Forces claimed to have struck weapons production sites in Iran, Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps said they fired another wave of attacks targeting Israel and American bases in the region.

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EDITORIAL
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Iranian Parliament mulls possible exit from nuclear treaty

Reuters
DUBAI

Iran's Parliament is reviewing a possible exit from the Nuclear Non-Proliferation Treaty (NPT), Foreign Ministry spokesperson Esmaeil Baghaei said on Monday, while insisting that Tehran has not and will not seek nuclear weapons.

"What is the benefit of joining a treaty in which bullying parties at the international level not only do not allow us to benefit from its rights but also attack our nuclear facilities?" Mr. Baghaei said, adding that Tehran would respect the treaty as long as it is a member.

Iran says its nuclear programme is for peaceful purpose and that as a signatory of the NPT it has the right to peaceful nuclear enrichment.

"Regarding membership in this treaty, regard-

Navy commander killed in Israeli strike, says Iran

TEHRAN
Iran confirmed on Monday that an Israeli strike had killed the commander of the naval force of the Revolutionary Guards, who Israel had said was responsible for the blocking of the Strait of Hormuz. Alireza Tangsiri "succumbed to severe injuries", it said. » **PAGE 14**

less of our clear position on the prohibition of all weapons of mass destruction, this is genuinely a debate taking place within public opinion and at the parliamentary level," he added.

In June 2025, the U.S. and Israel attacked Iran's key nuclear facilities. In the ongoing war, Israel targeted Iran's nuclear facilities again.

Spain closes airspace to U.S. planes linked to war

Associated Press
MADRID

Spain has closed its airspace to U.S. planes involved in the Iran war, Defence Minister Margarita Robles said on Monday.

The country had already said the U.S. could not use jointly operated military bases in the country for operations related to the conflict.

"This was made perfectly clear to the American military and forces from the very beginning. Therefore, neither the bases are authorised, nor, of course, is the use of Spanish airspace authorised for any actions related to the war in Iran," Ms. Robles said.

Spain's government has been Europe's most critical voice of U.S. and Israeli military actions in West Asia.

FULL REPORT ON
» **PAGE 14**

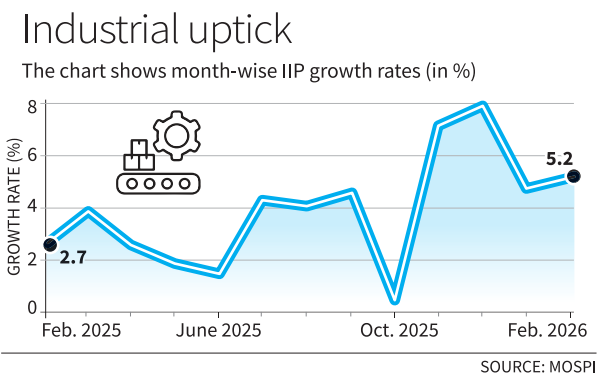
Manufacturing, capital goods lift IIP growth to 5.2% in Feb.

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Growth in India's industrial activity accelerated marginally to 5.2% in February, driven by a quickening of growth in the manufacturing and capital goods sectors, data released on Monday showed.

The data on the Index of Industrial Production for February, released by the Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation, shows that the final growth for January was also upgraded to 5.1% from the provisional 4.8% stated as part of last month's data release.

Within the Index, growth in the manufacturing sector accelerated to 6% in February, from 5.3% in the previous month. This was also considerably faster than the 2.8% in



growth in February last year. The mining and quarrying sector, on the other hand, saw growth slowing to a four-month low of 3.1% in February 2026, down from 4.3% in January. This was, however, faster than the 1.6% seen in February 2025.

Growth in the electricity sector, too, slowed to 2.3% in February 2026 from 5.1% in January.

"The growth is investment led, with basic metals, automobiles, machinery, and double digit gains in capital goods and infrastructure/construction goods pointing to a capex and infrastructure driven upcycle," Rajeev Sharan, Head of Research at Brickwork Ratings said.

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» **PAGE 10**

Uniform 50% LS seat hike to benefit North: Telangana CM

R. Ravikanth Reddy
HYDERABAD

Telangana Chief Minister A. Revanth Reddy has criticised the Centre's proposal to increase the number of Lok Sabha seats by a blanket 50% across all States, asserting that the move will disproportionately benefit northern States while leaving southern States politically marginalised.

He opposed the idea of applying a uniform 50% hike in every State as it would widen existing disparities, particularly disadvantaging the southern States. "The current difference in representation between States must be maintained," he said.

FULL REPORT ON
» **PAGE 7**

Stalin, Vijay and other leaders file their papers as ECI issues poll notification

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

DMK president and Tamil Nadu Chief Minister M.K. Stalin and Tamilaga Vettir Kazhagam (TVK) president C. Joseph Vijay were among the leaders who filed nominations on Monday, after the Election Commission of India (ECI) issued the official notification for the April 23 Assembly election in Tamil Nadu.

Mr. Stalin submitted his papers to the Returning Officer for the Kolathur constituency. Senior DMK leader and Minister P.K. Sekarababu and senior advo-



Set for the battle: DMK president and Chief Minister M. K. Stalin filing his nomination in Chennai on Monday. S.R. RAGHUNATHAN

cates R. Shunmugasundaram, R. Viduthalai, and N.R. Elango accompanied Mr. Stalin.

Mr. Vijay, who is making his debut in electoral polit-

ics, filed his nomination for Perambur.

DMK principal secretary and Minister K.N. Nehru filed his nomination for Tiruchi West and TVK leader

K.A. Sengottaiyan files nominations for Gobichettipalayam and Seeman for Karaikudi

K.A. Sengottaiyan for Gobichettipalayam. Naam Tamilar Katchi leader Seeman filed his nomination for Karaikudi.

As of 8.45 p.m. Monday, the details of over 560 nominations (some candidates have filed multiple nominations) were uploaded on the ECI portal.

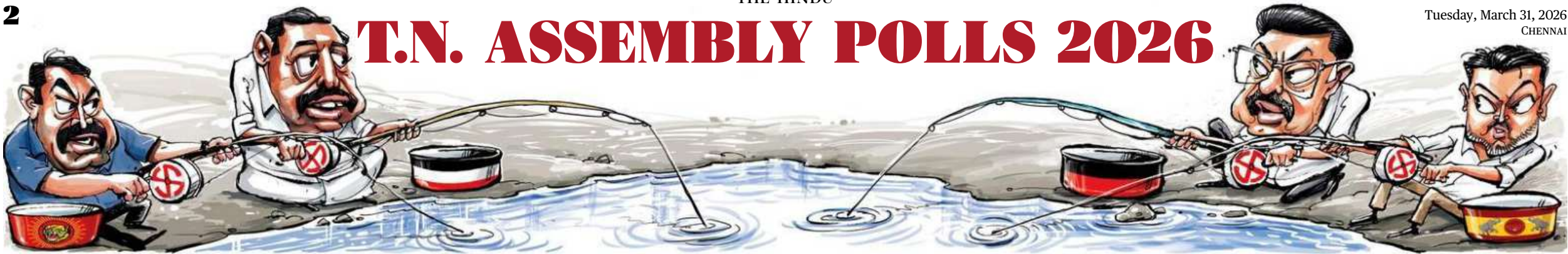
CONTINUED ON
» **PAGE 6**



PARLE PLATINA
CAN'T SAY NO TO MILANO
HIDE & SEEK MILANO COLLECTIONS
FINEST CHOCO FILLED BISCUITS
PARLE PLATINA
HIDE & SEEK MILANO COLLECTIONS
CHOCO & HAZELNUT CENTRE FILLED BISCUITS
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HIDE & SEEK MILANO COLLECTIONS
CHOCO CHIP BISCUITS
PARLE PLATINA
HIDE & SEEK MILANO COLLECTIONS
VANILLA CREME FILLED COCOA RICH BISCUITS
PARLE PLATINA
HIDE & SEEK MILANO COLLECTIONS
MIXED BERRIES CENTRE FILLED BISCUITS



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A lone voice amid the electoral cacophony

B. Kolappan
CHENNAI

Independent candidates are curious characters. The lack of money, muscle power, and organisational strength has never been an impediment to their entering the electoral fray, even when it is dominated by candidates of established political parties who have everything at their command. One among them was Poomedai Ramaiah.

Clad in a white khadi outfit and Gandhi cap, he would move around the streets of Nagercoil on his bicycle, putting up posters that minced no words about local politics and the inactivity of government offices, particularly the Nagercoil Municipal Corporation. ‘Poomedai 666 Watts; *Thottal Adikkum Shock*’ was a slogan that frequently appeared on his posters, boldly proclaiming his own “power”.

Kotti (roughly translating to “eccentric”), a short story from the collection *Aram Sirukathaikal* by writer Jayamohan, seeks to capture the character that was Poomedai Ramaiah. Not many took him seriously, yet he had his own band of followers who would gather at the grounds of the Nagercoil Municipality to attend his meetings. At times, these meetings were held near Veppamoodu Junction. He would carry his own table and chair, set them up, and hoist a white flag bearing the *poomedai* (a round flower garland). Local shopkeepers did not mind providing an electricity connection for a few hours to support his meetings. After all, the crowds often translated into more customers for nearby tea stalls.

Eloquent Gandhian

A Gandhian, he would begin his meetings with a prayer and slogans. Ramaiah had mastered the art of public speaking, and his speeches were often peppered with comic remarks. He could speak on local, national, and international politics with equal ease.

“At one meeting, he spoke about the attack on Kamaraj in Delhi, which he referred to as *Vadakku* [the North]. He then said he had asked a local Congress leader about the attack. But the Congressman replied that he had been busy with the harvest in the northern part of Kanniyakumari district,” recalled Professor V. Umaiyorubhagan.

Contrary to the claim – also found in Jayamohan’s story – that he was born in Kottaram, Ramaiah was born at Vadakku Thamaraiikulam in Kanniyakumari district. He lived in Kottaram when he fought with his brother. Ramaiah had participated in the freedom movement and the struggle to annex Kanniyakumari to Tamil Nadu. Well versed in the works of Vallalar Ramalinga Adigal, he also ran his own magazine *Meimurasu*.

Ramaiah was relatively wealthy and well read. “He was a member of the Communist Party but did not remain with it after the split in 1964. By that time, he had also earned a reputation as an eccentric. He lost most of his wealth by contesting in elections, organising meetings, and publishing his journal,” said 96-year-old N. Manickam, a CPI(M) leader.

Seeni chatti symbol

Mr. Manickam said Ramaiah also contested in the Suchindram town panchayat election, and his symbol was *seeni chatti* (frying pan). His rivals were Gopinath, a renowned CPI(M) leader, and Sornam Pillai, a local bigwig.

“Ramaiah would say the road roller of Sornam Pillai is fit only for the streets, and the pumpkin of Gopinath cannot be used a day after it is cooked. But *seeni chatti* can be kept permanently in the kitchen,” he said.

He used to contest on the *paanai* (pot) symbol; later, it became *aanai* (elephant). “Remember, our symbol is not *paanai*, but *aanai*,” he would remind voters. He contested in local bodies elections, Assembly elections, Lok Sabha elections, and by-elections. Well-wishers would pay for his deposit. But he never recovered it.

In the early 1990s, his voice gradually faded before falling silent. Mr. Manickam said he retired to a temple at Vadasery near Nagercoil and subsisted on temple food in his final years. He died in 1996.

INTERVIEW

Palanivel Thiagarajan

Sangeetha Kandavel
CHENNAI

DMK leader from Madurai and Tamil Nadu Information Technology Minister Palanivel Thiagarajan, who previously held the Finance portfolio, discusses the impact of the government’s welfare spending, actor C. Joseph Vijay’s political entry, and more in an interview to *The Hindu*. Edited excerpts:

Critics argue that the rising welfare commitments are straining the State’s finances. How do you justify this model?

The recent debate on this began when the Prime Minister [Narendra Modi] went on TV and said there has been a “revdi culture”. Even when I was an MLA, I had detailed discussions in which I explained that not all social or welfare spending – whatever label we use, including “freebies” – can be categorised in the same way. Some expenditures must be seen as investments in human development, such as the noon-meal scheme or providing laptops to students. Others function more like social protection or insurance schemes – such as health insurance support,

marriage assistance, or free rice for the poor.

Therefore, it is important to distinguish between different types of welfare and assess which ones genuinely add value. In fact, I cited a specific example of what I consider a poorly designed scheme: providing ₹25,000 per woman to purchase a scooter or powered two-wheeler. This runs counter to the broader policy objective of promoting public transport. Tamil Nadu already has a significant imbalance – around 2.9 crore registered two-wheelers for approximately 2.3 crore ration cards.

The effectiveness of such schemes depends on their design, intent, execution, and context. For instance, in remote areas where there are no buses, supporting access to two-wheelers may make sense. But in a State like Tamil Nadu – one of the most urbanised in the country, with more registered two-wheelers than families and an underutilised public transport system – the same policy may not be appropriate.

If a government focuses only on welfare spending, you will see immediate improvements in consumption, but it will not deliver long-term economic benefits. In a State like Tamil Nadu, where private consumption forms a significant share of the economy, increased transfers – such as the *Kalaigal Magalir Urimai Thogai* (a monthly rights grant of ₹1,000 for women heads of



Striking a balance: The IT Minister says if a government focuses only on welfare spending, it will lead to immediate improvement in consumption, but it won’t deliver long-term benefits. S. SHIVARAJ

family) and similar schemes – can boost consumption in the short term.

How do you view actor C. Joseph Vijay’s entry into politics?

As someone who believes democracy is the best model of a republic, I welcome anyone who enters the public sphere and is willing to stand before the people and seek their approval. I welcome new entrants and new ideas. If the entrant is a hugely popular actor, that is even better.

Why even better? Because the people who are the least engaged in politics are the youth. By definition, older people have fewer years ahead of them, whereas the youth have decades ahead of them. So, anything that increases youth engagement in politics, in my view, is a good thing. Ultimately, people will vote based on who they find reliable, expe-

rienced, and impactful. If he is a serious politician, I hope he is here for the long term. Even Perarignar Anna [former Chief Minister C.N. Annadurai] said that even for a strong government, a powerful Opposition is a good thing.

What about the DMK, is it getting younger?

The party, I think, is changing – particularly since the Deputy Chief Minister [Udhayanidhi Stalin] has been driving a significant change. This shift is attracting many young people to the party, which is good, as it was something that had been sorely missing before.

As a legislator, what tangible changes have you delivered to your constituency, Madurai Central, in the past five years?

I put out a detailed report every six months at a mi-

proved far more complex. It was originally initiated in 2010 under the then AIADMK Mayor and now MLA, Rajan Chellappa. The existing infrastructure is inadequate, and notably, the master plan for Madurai’s storm water and UGD systems dates back to 1908 during the British era and after that, there has not been a profound rethinking.

Upgrading integrated systems like storm water drainage and underground drainage is extremely challenging, especially ensuring that the two systems do not mix. Once they do, particularly during monsoon surges, the situation becomes unmanageable.

During my tenure as the Finance Minister, I allocated funds and initiated surveys to prepare Detailed Project Reports (DPRs). We now have two DPRs – one for a fully integrated UGD system, including multiple sewage treatment plants, and the other for a separate storm water management system, including canals. For a city like Madurai, these are long-term projects spanning 20-30 years. The first phase is set to begin shortly and has already been put out for tender.

As for the Kumbabhishekam, work is progressing. The mandapam [that was damaged in fire] will be opened soon. We sourced pillars, which matched the temple’s original stone, from a quarry in the Rasipuram region, enabling us to carry out the restoration appropriately.

AIADMK takes the lion’s share of seats that favoured the party in 2024 polls

T. Ramakrishnan
CHENNAI

The All India Anna Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (AIADMK) has taken the lion’s share of those Assembly seats, where the combined votes of the coalitions headed by it and the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) exceeded that of the DMK-led Secular Progressive Alliance (SPA) during the 2024 Lok Sabha election.

Had the two formations fought together, they would have been ahead of the SPA in 85 Assembly segments, by applying the yardstick of the 2024 voting trend. Of these seats, the Dravidian major has retained 65.

Of the remaining 19 Assembly segments, the BJP and the Pattali Makkal Katchi (PMK) have been allotted eight each, with one each to the Indhiya Jananayaga Katchi (IJK), Pularatchi Bharatham, and the Tamilaga Makkal Munnetra Kazhagam (TMMK).

In fact, in 2024, when the PMK was a constituent of the BJP-led National Democratic Alliance (NDA), it was ahead in three Assembly segments, of which two – Pennagaram and Dharmapuri – have been assigned to the party, the other being Pappireddipatti, where the AIADMK has



Missed opportunity: Had the BJP and AIADMK formations fought together in the 2024 Lok Sabha election, they would have been ahead of the SPA in 85 Assembly segments. B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM

Of the 65 seats won by the AIADMK in 2024, 31 are in the western region and 16 in the north

named its nominee.

It is also to be kept in mind that the Desiya Murpokku Dravida Kazhagam (DMDK), which was with the AIADMK in 2024, is now an ally of the DMK. Two years ago, it took the lead in two Assembly segments – Thirumangalam and Aruppukottai. Also, former Chief Minister O. Panneerselvam, who contested in Ramanathapuram as an independent under the NDA-fold two years ago, has been named as the DMK’s candidate for Bodinayakanur.

In terms of the region-

wise breakdown of the 65 seats netted by the AIADMK in 2024, 31 are in the western region, one of the strongholds of the party and the home region of many of its leaders such as general secretary Edappadi K. Palaniswami (Edappadi), deputy general secretary K.P. Munusamy (Veppanahalli), and former Ministers P. Thangamani (Kumarapalayam) and S.P. Velumani (Thondamuthur). The party, on its own, was ahead in Edappadi and Kumarapalayam, apart from six others.

Sixteen Assembly segments are in the northern districts – which include Mailam, where former Law Minister C.Ve. Shanmugam is going to contest – while 14 are in the south.

The central or Cauvery delta region, where the

party could win only four seats during the 2021 Assembly polls, accounts for four, which include Virali-malai and Vedaranyam. Both are being represented by the AIADMK’s former Ministers, C. Vijayabaskar and O.S. Manian.

Seats for other parties

As for the BJP, Avanashi, Rasipuram, Coimbatore (North), and Sattur – identified for the party’s leading figures, including Nainar Nagenthiran – are among the advantageous seats.

In the case of the PMK, Gingee and Vikravandi are some such places.

The other three seats – Kunnam, K.V. Kupparam, and Rajapalayam – have been allocated to IJK, Pularatchi Bharatham, and the TMMK.

When MGR’s cut-outs pulled in the masses

B. Aravind Kumar
CHENNAI

M.G. Ramachandran (MGR) had grown in influence by the 1971 elections, when he was the DMK treasurer.

C. Rajagopalachari (Rajaji) and Kamaraj had joined hands in a grand alliance. The thespian Sivaji Ganesan was being propped as their star campaigner. By now, differences had begun creeping in between MGR and then Chief Minister M. Karunanidhi.

After floating the ADMK (now AIADMK) in 1972, MGR started drawing bigger crowds. When he visited Coimbatore, people broke barricades and stormed the aircraft upon its landing.

In 1977, MGR adopted a novel method of campaigning by sending his life-size cut-outs in jeeps to villages in his rural Arupukottai constituency in Ramanathapuram district.

Huge crowds sometimes waited for hours running late into the night to have a glimpse of their hero’s cutout. The AIADMK leader, pressed for time, took to this method as he felt he could not cover the entire constituency at once. It consisted of 256 villages, some of which were not accessible by any mode of transport, except on foot.



MGR campaigned by sending life-size cut-outs in jeeps to villages in his constituency.

According to a report in *The Hindu*, when the jeeps with his cut-outs were driven through the villages, many people, including women, performed ‘arti’ and broke coconuts. A record player in the vehicles played specially-composed songs – sung by popular playback singers – praising MGR, followed by his messages promising progressive measures.

Pro-poor promises

In 1980, MGR began a tour of his Madurai West constituency with the blessings of the Bishop of Madurai. At Kallipatti, he assured farmers that if his party returned to power, he would ensure that their debts were written off and repaid to the Reserve Bank by the State government, without seeking the Centre’s aid, reinforcing his image as the “saviour of the poor”.

Scattered rainfall likely in most parts of the State; heat to remain under check, says RMC

MDRF partners with Premas Life Sciences to strengthen research

13 police officers from State conferred with IPS by Union govt.

47 nominations filed across constituencies in Chennai district

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Tamil Nadu

From Page One

Stalin, Vijay and other leaders file nominations

An official release from Chief Electoral Officer Archana Patnaik said a total of 3,32,231 officials were trained in subjects related to duties, roles, and responsibilities of presiding officers and polling officials.

Witnessing greater support: CM

After filing his nomination, Mr. Stalin said he was witnessing greater support than in the previous three elections he had won in Kolathur. “It is a battle between Tamil Nadu and Delhi. It is going to be a big victory to save Tamil Nadu,” he said. Later, at an interaction with the alliance partners at the DMK headquarters, Anna Arivalayam, Mr. Stalin said the DMK-led alliance was not a new formation but one that had already contested in two Lok Sabha elections, an Assembly election, local bodies elections, and by-elections. “It is a mega alliance. Nowhere in India is such an alliance continuing for so many years. Now, some more parties have joined our alliance,” he said.

INBRIEF

Sowmiya Anbumani to contest from Dharmapuri

PMK president Anbumani Ramadoss on Monday announced that Sowmiya Anbumani, his spouse and president of NGO Pasumai Thayagam, would contest from the party’s stronghold, Dharmapuri, in the Assembly election. Dr. Anbumani released the full list of candidates for 15 constituencies. PMK treasurer M. Thilagabama will take on actor Vijay and R.D. Sekar of the DMK in Perambur. The party has nominated Anbumani Cholan in Kattumannarkovil, from where VCK president Thol. Thirumavalavan is seeking election.

‘Welfare schemes are social investments, stimulus to economy’

Explaining the DMK’s manifesto, party leader Kanimozhi says when the people have money, it automatically increases their purchasing power

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

DMK Parliamentary party leader Kanimozhi said on Monday that there was an attempt to politicise welfare schemes as “freebies”, though economists across the world, including former Union Finance Minister P. Chidambaram, had explained how such financial assistance acted as a stimulus to the economy.

Explaining various aspects of the DMK manifesto, she said when people have money, it automatically increased their purchasing power and stimulated the economy. “The Magalir Urimai Thittam, under which ₹1,000 is given to women, increases their purchasing power. Zero cost bus travel has allowed women to travel in search of jobs. The money spent by the government on these schemes is a social investment. Only those who are against social justice will oppose these schemes,” she said.

Responding to the allegation that the DMK had



Kanimozhi

copied the AIADMK manifesto, Ms. Kanimozhi said nobody would take the promises of the AIADMK seriously because many of them had not been fulfilled.

“The AIADMK announced promises without realising that these schemes are already being implemented by the Dravidian Model government. Women are already receiving ₹1,000, and the Chief Minister has announced that it will be increased to ₹2,000. Now, the AIADMK has come out with the same promise,” she said.

According to her, the

DMK’s manifesto had received all-round appreciation.

Inputs from the people

“The manifesto committee travelled to many districts and elicited opinions and suggestions from people from all walks of life. We have prepared the manifesto based on 80,000 ideas from experts across various fields. The Chief Minister is particular that all the promises should be implementable,” she said.

Asked how the DMK government would identify beneficiaries for the Illatharasi scheme, under which women would be given a coupon worth ₹8,000 to purchase or replace household appliances, she said the government was already providing ₹1,000 per month to 1.31 crore women and it would not be difficult to identify deserving beneficiaries.

Ms. Kanimozhi said the objective behind the scheme was to free women from time-consuming household work and give them more time to pursue their interests.

DMK once allied with BJP to make Murasoli Maran Union Minister, says EPS

The Hindu Bureau
TENKASI

The DMK, which had aligned with the BJP in 1999 “to secure a Union Minister berth for Murasoli Maran” in the Atal Bihari Vajpayee-led government, is now portraying the AIADMK as anti-minority to gain minority votes, AIADMK general secretary Edappadi K. Palaniswami said on Monday.

Addressing an election rally in the Muslim-majority town of Kadayannallur, Mr. Palaniswami accused DMK president and Chief Minister M.K. Stalin of diverting public attention. He said since the DMK could not point out any flaws in the AIADMK’s governance, it was framing the upcoming election as a “battle between Tamil Nadu and Delhi” and branding the AIADMK as anti-minority due to its alliance with the BJP.

He further said the DMK itself had partnered with the BJP in 1999, when Murasoli Maran served as a Union Minister, and alleged that the party was now misleading minorities for electoral gain. “We have always been the armour for minorities,” Mr.



AIADMK general secretary Edappadi K. Palaniswami campaigning at Kadayannallur in Tenkasi district.

Palaniswami said showing the photo of then Chief Minister M. Karunanidhi and Murasoli Maran sharing a dais at a political event.

Highlighting pro-minority measures, he listed schemes such as distribution of rice during Ramadan, support for the Nagore Dargah, Hajj subsidies, construction of a Hajj House in Chennai, and the Quaid-e-Milleth memorial.

‘DMK copied manifesto’

He also said while the AIADMK supported A.P.J. Abdul Kalam in the Presidential election, the DMK opposed him. Additionally, he accused the DMK of copying AIADMK’s manifesto

and criticised its ₹8,000 appliance token scheme as a “scam.”

“While we have promised to give you free refrigerator and credit ₹10,000 in your account for buying a home appliance of your choice since you have been hit hard by inflation, you will be compelled to buy a particular home appliance in the DMK’s token system, which will ultimately ensure monetary benefits to the party, and hence, it is a scam,” Mr. Palaniswami charged.

Outlining the AIADMK’s promises, Mr. Palaniswami said the party would provide ₹25,000 to working women for electric scooters, increase rural employment days to 150, offer ₹2,000 monthly assistance to unemployed graduates, distribute silk saris during Pongal, and provide three free LPG cylinders annually.

He alleged that the DMK had failed to fulfil even 25% of its 2021 poll promises, while asserting that the AIADMK would deliver on all its commitments. He also vowed to curb drug-related activities and investigate illegal mineral extraction.

T.N. needs to be saved from the DMK: TVK chief Vijay

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Beginning his election campaign in the Perambur constituency, where he is making his electoral debut, Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK) president C. Joseph Vijay on Monday said Tamil Nadu needed to be saved from the DMK.

Addressing cadre and supporters in Kodungaiyur, Mr. Vijay said the State was currently facing serious issues such as lack of women’s safety, poor law and order, and the increasing proliferation of narcotic substances. “The DMK is the reason for this condition of the State,” he said. Questioning governance under the DMK regime, he asked how people could live without access to basic amenities and safety.

Later, he also campaigned for his party’s nominee in the Kolathur Assembly segment, where Chief Minister M.K. Stalin



TVK president C. Joseph Vijay campaigning in Perambur constituency on Monday. B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM

is contesting for the fourth time.

Campaign cancelled

Originally, Mr. Vijay was scheduled to campaign in the Perambur, Kolathur, and Villivakkam Assembly segments from 2 p.m. till late evening on Monday. However, he began his campaign earlier than scheduled. He only addressed the public for a few minutes in both Perambur and Kolathur Assembly segments. He did

not proceed to Villivakkam as planned. The party cited lack of security as the reason for the change in schedule.

In a statement, party general secretary N. Anand alleged proper arrangements to ensure the safety of people and traffic diversion were not made along the route where Mr. Vijay was scheduled to speak in Kolathur and Villivakkam. He said the campaign in Villivakkam had to be cancelled considering the safety of Mr. Vijay and the public. The party also wrote to the Election Commission citing lapses in security arrangements. In a letter to the Chief Electoral Officer, TVK joint general secretary C.T.R. Nirmal Kumar claimed there was “absolutely no police deployment or traffic management provided by authorities” for Mr. Vijay’s convoy when it proceeded from Perambur to Kolathur.

Vijay declares nearly ₹625 crore in assets

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK) president C. Joseph Vijay has declared in his election affidavit that he has ₹404.58 crore in movable assets and ₹220.15 crore in immovable assets.

He has also declared ₹15.51 crore in movable assets and ₹2.5 crore in immovable assets in the name of his spouse Sangeetha.

Mr. Vijay filed his nomination to contest from the Perambur Assembly constituency at Dr. Ambedkar Government Arts College (Autonomous) at Vyasarpadi on Monday before beginning his campaign.

According to his affidavit, the movable assets include 883 grams of gold, five cars, and a two-wheeler in his name and 3,132 grams of gold and 134.91 karats of diamond in the name of his spouse. He has ₹2 lakh in cash,

Educational background

TVK president C. Joseph Vijay has declared that he completed Class X in 1989 and Class XII in 1991 through private study under the Tamil Nadu State Board and dropped out of Loyola College in 1992 while pursuing a Bachelor of Science degree.

while his spouse has ₹1 lakh.

Mr. Vijay has given loans to several persons and companies, including ₹3.02 crore to his father S.A. Chandrasekhar; ₹87.12 lakh to his mother Shobha Chandrasekhar; ₹12.6 crore to his spouse; ₹8.78 lakh to his son Jason Sanjay; and ₹4.6 lakh to his daughter Divya Sasha, according to the affidavit.

He has also said there were no criminal cases pending against him.

Chief Minister Stalin’s assets estimated at ₹6.25 crore

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Chief Minister M.K. Stalin on Monday declared assets worth ₹6.25 crore, as part of the affidavit submitted when he filed his nomination papers for the Kolathur constituency. Of this, the moveable assets are worth ₹3.3 crore and immovable assets worth ₹2.95 crore.

In the affidavit furnished before the Returning Officer on Monday, Mr. Stalin stated that his deposits amounted to ₹2.8 crore. The current market value of 50% of the 5,833 sq.ft residential building owned by him in Velachery is ₹1.57 crore. The current market value of the 25% of the 3,620 sq.ft residential building owned by him in Tiruvarur is ₹20.26 lakh.

Mr. Stalin is a resident of Teynampet, falling in the Mylapore constituency.

Seeman declares assets worth ₹3.74 cr.

The Hindu Bureau
KARAIKUDI

Naam Tamilar Katchi (NTK) chief coordinator Seeman filed his nomination papers for the Karaikudi constituency at the Devakottai Sub-Collector’s office on Monday.

Mr. Seeman, who came along with his mother Annammal, wife Kayalvizhi, and party functionaries, submitted his nomination papers to Returning Officer and Sub-Collector Ayush Venkat Vats.

Following this, his wife Kayalvizhi filed her nomination as the substitute candidate for him. The affidavit attached with the nomination documents noted that Seeman and his wife possessed assets worth ₹3.74 crore. Mr. Seeman has ₹50,000 in cash on hand, ₹7.72 lakh in bank deposits, a car valued at ₹12 lakh, and 150 grams of gold worth ₹19.50 lakh, totalling ₹39.81 lakh in movable assets.



Seeman

His total debt is ₹5.11 lakh. Further, there were 24 cases pending against him, but he has not been convicted in any of them. His wife has ₹35,000 in cash on hand, ₹5.27 lakh in bank deposits, ₹3.5 lakh in share investments, two cars valued at ₹25 lakh and ₹4 lakh, and 1,600 grams of gold valued at ₹2.08 crore, totalling ₹2.57 crore in movable assets.

Regarding immovable assets, she possessed 25.45 acres of agricultural land valued at ₹51 lakh and 10 acres of non-agricultural land valued at ₹36 lakh, totalling ₹87 lakh. Her total debt is ₹18.29 lakh.

CPI(M) names candidates for five seats

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The CPI(M)’s State unit on Monday announced its candidates for five Assembly constituencies. The party has retained M. Chinnadurai, the sitting MLA from the Gandarvakottai constituency, but replaced Nagai Mali with D. Latha in Kizhvelur, as he had completed two terms in the Assembly.

The candidate for the Padmanabhapuram constituency is R. Chellasamy, the party’s district secretary in Kanniyakumari district. In Palani, the party has fielded N. Pandi, a member of its State secretariat.

In Tiruvottiyur, L. Sundararajan, a member of its State committee, has been fielded.

Candidates to be announced soon, says Selvaperunthagai

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Tamil Nadu Congress Committee president K. Selvaperunthagai on Monday said the party candidates for the Assembly election would be announced in a day or two, after the AICC central election committee meets.

“If the committee meets soon, the candidates will be announced by tomorrow or day after,” he said. Mr. Selvaperunthagai said the CPI (M) would field its candidate in Padmanabhapuram, ruling out possibility of swapping the seat within the DMK-led alliance.

Pennagaram ticket

With the list of Congress candidates yet to be released, some senior lead-



K. Selvaperunthagai

ers have reportedly opposed a proposal to give the ticket for Pennagaram to former Pattali Makkal Katchi (PMK) president G.K. Mani’s son G.K.M. Tamil Kumaran. Sources said senior leader K.V. Thangakabalu and two MPs – Karti P. Chidambaram and S. Jothimani – have opposed the move to nominate Mr. Kumaran. Sources claimed that

Mr. Kumaran’s candidature was backed by a senior TNCC leader and a Congress MP.

“That is when many of us realised that the groundwork had already been laid and some kind of agreement had been reached. It is completely unacceptable,” a leader said.

Mr. Thangakabalu reportedly expressed surprise when Mr. Kumaran’s name was proposed. “Mr. Thangakabalu, in fact, said, ‘Let Mr. Kumaran first join the party and meet the Congress leaders’ He took exception to the manner in which the ticket is being pushed through,” a source said.

A leader said it was time for self-introspection on how such decisions could reflect on the party in Tamil Nadu.

Sattankulam custodial deaths: sentencing posted to Apr. 2 after delay in govt. reports

B. Tilak Chandar
MADURAI

With the Union and the State governments’ reports on aggravating/mitigating circumstances awaited, the First Additional District and Sessions Court in Madurai on Monday posted the Sattankulam custodial deaths case of trader P. Jayaraj, 58, and his son J. Benicks, 31, for sentencing to April 2.

Nearly six years after Jayaraj and Benicks died of custodial torture during COVID-19 lockdown at the Sattankulam police station in Thoothukudi district, the First Additional District and Sessions Judge G. Muthukumar on March 23 convicted all nine police personnel accused in the case. The judge had posted



Due process: The convicted police personnel being brought to the court in Madurai on Monday. R. ASHOK

the matter to March 30 for pronouncing the quantum of sentence.

The judge found the police personnel guilty of murder and other offences under the Indian Penal Code (IPC) and had sought a report on the medical condition of the police personnel and a report on the last property statements and salary certificates of

the accused. Furthermore, the judge had sought a report from the Union and State governments as to the aggravating/mitigating circumstances. With the Union and the State governments reports awaited, the matter was posted to April 2.

All nine convicts were produced before the court. The remand of the convicts

has been extended till April 2.

The crime, which took place in June 2020. The Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI), which investigated the case, filed a charge sheet on September 25, 2020 and followed it up with a supplementary charge sheet on August 12, 2022.

Ten police personnel were named as accused in the case: the then Sattankulam inspector, S. Sridhar; sub-inspectors P. Raghu Ganesh and K. Balakrishnan; head constables S. Murugan and A. Saamidurai; and constables M. Muthuraj, S. Cheladurai, X. Thomas Francis, and S. Veilumuthu. Special sub-inspector Pauldurai was also an accused. But he died during trial after contracting COVID-19.

A.P. govt. aims at building 17 lakh houses by 2029: Naidu

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Going downhill

A ground invasion of Iran will only make matters worse for the U.S.

President Donald Trump has made several self-contradictory statements ever since the U.S. and Israel attacked Iran on February 28, making it increasingly difficult to take anything that he says about the war seriously. In the early days, he insisted that the conflict would end soon, but it has now entered its second month. On March 21, he threatened to strike Iran’s power plants in 48 hours unless Tehran reopened the Strait of Hormuz. The waterway remains under Iranian control, and Mr. Trump has extended his deadline twice. Despite his repeated claims that U.S. forces destroyed Iran’s military capabilities, Tehran continues to attack U.S. bases in the Persian Gulf and Israel. Last week, U.S. media reported that an Iranian strike at the Prince Sultan Air Base in Saudi Arabia damaged an elite E-3 Sentry AWACS aircraft and several KC-135 aerial refuelling tankers. Mr. Trump now says that his administration is in talks with Iran and a deal is possible. But Iran says that it has got a U.S. proposal to end the war and has made its counter-proposal. The U.S. wants Iran to abandon its nuclear programme, limit its missile programme and reopen the Strait; Tehran demands war reparations, guarantees against future attacks and an end to fighting on “all fronts”. Amid disputed claims about the talks, the U.S. is also sending more combat troops to West Asia in preparation for a possible ground attack.

Mr. Trump appears to have no easy exit. The Strait of Hormuz was open before he launched the war. Ending the conflict now while the waterway remains under Iranian control would seem like a defeat. The U.S. had a robust military footprint in the region. Today, most American bases in the Gulf have been battered. In Iran, Ayatollah Ali Khamenei’s assassination voided his fatwa against the nuclear bomb, and its parliament is considering withdrawing from the Nuclear Non-Proliferation Treaty. Crude prices, under \$80 a barrel before the war, are now hovering around \$114 a barrel. Iran, which was under heavy sanctions, is making more money now because of the wartime sanctions relief. This war is already a disaster for the U.S., and Mr. Trump would worsen it by sending ground troops. The U.S. has not mobilised enough combat troops to launch a large-scale ground invasion. Many argue that the U.S. could try to seize some islands in the Gulf for leverage, but any attack would be extremely risky for both troops and the global economy. Mr. Trump’s escalatory rhetoric, including threats to strike Iran’s civilian infrastructure only underscores his desperation. Instead of digging deeper into the hole he has put himself in, he must start looking for a way out. A ground attack would close even the few remaining off-ramps he has.

Spirit of the law

Any attempt to police faith will result in high-handedness

Legislation passed by Maharashtra and Chhattisgarh recently on religious conversions misleadingly claims to protect freedom of religion but effectively does the opposite. Laws made by both States restrict the individual freedom of faith through requirements of prior permission from the state, public disclosure, and by shifting the burden of proof to the accused. These States now join at least 10 others in having detailed legal restrictions on an individual’s right to practise and profess any religion of their choice. It is true that the state has a duty to protect all citizens from force and fraud. But when that principle is applied to test whether a person’s religious faith is an outcome of criminal force or fraud, it is a leap into chaotic darkness even with the best of intentions. What goes on in a person’s mind, such as matters of faith, is not accessible to another person in its entirety, and any attempt to police faith will invariably lead to high-handedness. A batch of petitions challenging these laws has been pending before the Supreme Court of India, and the final status of the new laws in Maharashtra and Chhattisgarh will also be linked to the final determination of the constitutionality of such laws by the Court. Meanwhile, the laws will disturb social order and harmony, achieving the exact opposite of what they purportedly set out to do.

The provisions are harsh, intrusive and authoritarian. Under the Maharashtra law, a person intending to convert must give 60 days’ notice and seek prior permission from a designated authority. Conversion must be registered within 25 days, or it will be treated as null and void. The authority will publish the notice locally, including at the relevant gram panchayat, inviting objections within 30 days. If objections are received, the authority may direct police to conduct an inquiry. The Chhattisgarh legislation also has similar provisions, but additionally exempts reconversion to one’s ancestral religion from its purview. Even community religious gatherings can attract provisions of the Chhattisgarh law, which replaces a 1968 law made by undivided Madhya Pradesh. Anti-conversion laws are premised on a lack of agency of the individual and driven by an ideological framework that links nationality to faith. In a less passionate and more reasonable framing, a person’s change of faith is no different from their decision to change their passport, political affiliation, or place of residence – all of which are legal. In any case, religions have no basis in verifiable scientific facts, and propagation of religion, a constitutionally guaranteed right, can easily be misrepresented as fraud. By seeking to resolve a problem that does not exist, the Bharatiya Janata Party is serving only its own narrow political interests.

Elections come and go in India with predictable regularity; largely and more predictable because a new legislature must be constituted before the house reaches the end of its term. Combined with the practice of bunching elections together for logistical efficiency, the timing of polls becomes no big mystery.

Elections to the Legislative Assemblies of Assam, Kerala, Puducherry, Tamil Nadu and West Bengal, announced earlier this month, stand apart as they follow the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls, which has not only pared down electoral rolls but also added to the political tensions between the Opposition parties in power in these States and the party ruling at the Centre. But that is not all.

Work extraordinary, the scale and phases

Setting up elections across 2.19 lakh polling stations in four States and one Union Territory, including those in the farthest corners, is no easy task even for a country with 75 years of electoral democracy. For example, polling officials trek three hours in the challenging terrain of the Varusanad hills in Tamil Nadu’s Theni district to serve five electors at the Vellimalai polling station. In Kerala’s Idukki, officials have to travel through 30 kilometres of rugged off-road terrain, followed by an eight kilometre walk to reach the Edamalakuddy booth. Polling teams in Assam make it to the remote Dhanekhana polling station after a journey over nearly 60 km by ferry, road and crossing the Brahmaputra river.

Over 25 lakh election officials will serve a 17.4 crore electorate in these elections, making it one official for every 70 electors. The number includes 8.5 lakh security personnel and 49,000 micro observers. In the midst of doubts being raised over the neutrality of officials, Section 28A of the Representation of the People Act binds their allegiance solely to the Election Commission of India (ECI). Over 1,100 central observers have already moved to the Assembly constituencies to make sure that nothing goes wrong.

The ECI has also made – and is still making – sizeable changes among senior administrative and police officials with the objective of ensuring fair polls, even as State governments such as West Bengal have been severely critical of these moves. Ideally, someday, heightened civic responsibility should make the deployment of forces around polling stations and poll time shifting of officials redundant.

Efforts in recent years to complete polling in the fewest possible phases suggest maturing election management and better governance. Multiple phases are often been attributed to the availability and movement of security forces, required to safeguard the integrity of polls. Polling days in politically volatile West Bengal



Akshay Rout

A former Director General, Election Commission of India

Upholding integrity in India’s elections is a shared challenge for voters, parties and officials

have been reduced to two phases – a significant reduction from the eight phases in 2021. This would be a confidence booster for election managers once concluded smoothly.

The four ‘M’ challenge

The ECI has said that these elections will be violence and inducement free. During the 2024 general election, the ECI had declared a war on the 4Ms – ‘Money’, ‘Muscle’, ‘Misinformation’ and ‘Model Code of Conduct (MCC)’ violations.

With strong security and practically indestructible electronic voting machines, elections in India have been largely free from open threats of muscle power; but polarised campaigns and the desperation of some political parties continue to pose challenges to the conduct of peaceful elections. West Bengal has a chequered history of election-related violence, especially acts of post-poll vengeance. The State has been on the radar of the ECI for several weeks now – the vulnerability should be lower, but fingers crossed. The ECI has ordered round-the-clock live webcasting of all polling stations.

Electoral inducements, in cash or kind, have long persisted in electoral politics irrespective of concerns being expressed in important fora from time to time, court observations and sporadic public debates. Electoral inducements now drive fierce political competition. Political parties and candidates have experienced the profitable effect of this malignant strategy. Cash transfers from governments to targeted groups just before the announcement of polls is routine – in these elections as well – with the ECI again clarifying that its ruling commences only after the MCC comes into force. Campaign freebies abound, and party manifestos often flout fiscal logic in a free-for-all manner. Moves by the Supreme Court of India and the ECI to rein in the ‘promise bazaar’ have made little headway.

Enforcement agencies monitor polling areas closely, aiming to catch bribes in action and tracking the inflow of cash, liquor, drugs, and other goodies including digital transactions. In the 2024 general election, the authorities seized over ₹10,000 crore worth of inducement material countrywide, almost three times the amount seized in 2019. Tamil Nadu, more than the other States, will be tested once again. In 2021, inducement material worth over ₹1,000 crore was seized in five States, almost half of it from Tamil Nadu. Specially constituted field units – 5,200 static surveillance teams and an equal number of flying squads – will be expected to deliver a stellar performance. Over ₹400 crore worth of illicit inducements have been seized in the first month.

Election managers have long faced offensive, misleading and inflammatory advertisements

A flame the state cannot guarantee



Rahul Verma

An independent researcher and sociology educator

The West Asian war-driven LPG disruptions reveal weaknesses in India’s clean cooking system

failed. India imports about 60% of its LPG consumption and 90% of those imports pass through the Strait of Hormuz. India’s Strategic Petroleum Reserves cover about 9.5 days of crude oil supply and are currently at 64% capacity, with no equivalent LPG-specific buffer. The state’s ability to meet its clean cooking targets depends entirely on uninterrupted global commodity flows, while the welfare architecture – designed to scale uptake – was not built to ensure continuity under stress.

Gaps in a sovereign responsibility

The PMUY promise was built on visible markers of sovereign responsibility. Government branding on the cylinder, the Direct Benefit Transfer credit in the woman’s account, and the scheme’s naming after the Prime Minister – all signalling that the state was present and accountable. The war in West Asia and the LPG crisis exposes that communication and capacity were never aligned. The branding belonged to the state while the supply chain moved through markets and chokepoints that the state observed from a distance once the transition to LPG was complete. But when the Strait of Hormuz closes, the sovereign guarantee has no physical infrastructure behind it.

The cost of that misalignment is not distributed neutrally. One in four PMUY beneficiaries took only one refill or none at all in normal times, because refill costs exceeded what the subsidy covered for the poorest quintiles. With mandatory booking gaps at 45 days for rural areas and 25 days for urban areas and prices rising by ₹60 a cylinder in March, those households are the first to revert to biomass and the last to receive any relief when allocations tighten. Scheduled Caste and tribal households have 10% to 30% lower LPG access than upper-caste households, independent of income, partly because distributor networks in segregated rural geographies replicate caste hierarchies in how they allocate scarce supply. A war in West Asia activates those hierarchies.

close to polling day, leaving little room for rebuttal. The ECI has now banned political advertisements in the print media on poll day and one day prior to poll day unless pre-certified. A voluntary code of ethics for social media platforms – to prevent spurious use – has been only moderately effective, so poll officials aim to hold candidates’ accounts more accountable for content and expenditure, tighten offline media regulation, and swiftly counter fake news and deepfakes on digital media.

The contests in 2021 in these States/Union Territory saw several violations of the model code, with appeals to caste, religion, sect, and ethnicity. In this election, Kerala’s multiethnic fabric and West Bengal’s majority-minority dynamics are under strain, which could intensify closer to polling day. Regulators will be closely watched, though some argue that all types of verbal assaults should fall under free speech rather than make a futile attempt at ensuring a balancing act.

These are four States and a Union Territory with a high degree of political awareness. These are also States and a Union Territory with a record of high voter turnout between 70% and 80%. The SIR process, which has removed absentee, shifted, and deceased voters, is expected to boost participation figures. Over the past one and a half decades, the ECI’s Systematic Voters’ Education and Electoral Participation (SVEEP) programme has enhanced voter engagement. Collection of votes from the homes of electors over 85 years and persons with disabilities is a standout measure. Facility to deposit mobile phones at polling booths and ensuring colour photographs of candidates and larger font size on the EVM ballot are citizen-friendly innovations.

The duty of the voter

The voter’s task will be to protect the sacred character of his entitlement from the acid rain of political campaigning and to make a moral choice at the electoral booth. Voter education has to be directed towards developing a civic resistance against blaring insinuations and provocations. Politicians should not be allowed a free walk over the moral judgement of the citizen-voter by gifts of cash and kind or false promise, or falsification of opponents. Falling prey to fake and seasonal narratives is an insult to the power of the vote and the Constitution of India. Let the elections this summer be a win for India and its citizens in the four States and Union Territory. Even while candidates and political parties score their victories and defeats, let election managers derive satisfaction from yet another successful exercise.

The views expressed are personal

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Conflict in West Asia

Escalating rhetoric in the Iran war underscores how fragile the region’s balance has become. Iran’s defiance, Pakistan’s mediation, and the involvement of regional powers reveal both opportunity and peril. Peace efforts risk being overshadowed by military posturing, yet the

alternative is catastrophe. **K. Chidanand Kumar,** Bengaluru

Campaign remarks

In his recent election campaign in Kerala, the Prime Minister’s remarks labelling his party as the ‘A team’ and alleging systemic misgovernance by the LDF warrant scrutiny. While

political rhetoric is expected in the run-up to the elections, it should not overshadow the key issue of federal fiscal responsibility. Rather than making “tall promises” reserved for election cycles, the Union government must ensure that the State receives its entitled share of resources based on merit and

constitutional norms. Labelling the State as marked by “corruption and misgovernance” ignores

Kerala’s strong social indicators. Past comparisons to Somalia were unfounded. True

Corrections & Clarifications

Andhra Pradesh has India’s third-longest coastline, not the second-longest as stated in the first paragraph of an article, “Andhra Pradesh poised for a leap in shipbuilding and ship repair cluster” (‘Business’ page, March 29).

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cooperative federalism requires the Centre to support the State through action and fiscal cooperation, rather than disparaging its progress from a campaign podium.

S. Padmanabhan, Kochi, Kerala

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address.

Ensuring federalism within delimitation

Article 81 of the Constitution states that seats should be distributed among States and within constituencies based on population such that “the ratio between the number and the population of the State is, so far as practicable, the same for all States”. That ratio was similar in 1951 and 1971, since State populations had not diverged much. However, that situation does not hold any longer.

As India has become the world’s most populous nation, and since Census 2026 is right around the corner, the delimitation exercise will also become due shortly. The 84th Constitutional Amendment Act, 2002 extended the freeze on the number of seats in Parliament and State Legislatures from 2000 to 2026, stating that, “keeping in view the progress of family planning programmes in different parts of the country, the government, ...decided ...as a motivational measure to enable the state governments to pursue the agenda for population stabilisation.” Hence, Lok Sabha seats shall “remain unaltered till the first Census to be taken after the year 2026.” The Census results will be declared by October 2028, after which the Delimitation Commission (DC) will be constituted. After the outcome is declared, the 2029 Lok Sabha elections will follow.

Equal share to all

Given the constitutional amendment, it is legitimate to consider how much convergence has been achieved between fertility rates over the last two decades. The author examined which States had achieved a Total Fertility Rate (TFR) needed to stabilise population growth, that is, 2.1 births per woman. The National Family Health Surveys (NFHS) were used for this analysis. As per the findings of the third NFHS (2005-6), which is the closest survey to the 2002 constitutional amendment, in



Santosh Mehrotra
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Democracy is about fair voice, and not just raw numbers. Federal stability matters as much as electoral arithmetic

2005, nine States (Himachal, Punjab, Delhi, Goa, Andhra (incl Telengana), Karnataka, Kerala, and Tamil Nadu) had achieved a TFR of 2.1 or less. By 2021, most major States had achieved a TFR of 2.1 except five States (Bihar, U.P., Jharkand, Meghalaya and Manipur).

Clearly, while there was an improvement in the TFR across the country, the mean TFR among States below the national TFR mean was 1.64, while the corresponding mean for States above the national mean was 2.38. Thus, those States which have a higher mean than the national mean, in the latest NFHS-5 (2019-21), are still 45% higher, with respect to fertility rates, than that of early achievers. Therefore, based on the 2002 constitutional amendment, and in light of this analysis, it is being suggested here that seat allocation should, post the 2026 Census, also be partially subject to this differential performance. However, how much weight should be given to States’ population stabilisation efforts in determining seat allocation in the delimitation exercise?

Here, the logic underlying the Finance Commission (FC) can be considered. The FC uses, in addition to total population size (50% weight), various other criteria for allocating finances to States such as demographic performance, which rewards States for improved population growth. The delimitation exercise could also reward/penalise States for demographic performance. To arrive at the number of seats allotted per State, the DC could propose the following based on population size and the Demographic Performance (DemPer) of States.

No change is to be made to the seat allocation by State for the prevailing 543 seats in the Lok Sabha as of 2024; the DemPer principle can be applied only to the additional seats (over the existing 543), meaning that the population principle still remains overwhelmingly dominant.

Moreover, there are dimensions to the DemPer principle – first, early achievement (TFR of 2.1 or less before 2005), should be given only 10% weightage in the estimation of seat allocation to a State, and second, the rate of decline in TFR between 2005 and 2021 should be given 90% weightage. The main outcome of the application of these principles is that all States experience an increase in the number of seats, with the more populous States receiving more seats in absolute terms than the less populous ones. This system also ensures that the share of States that performed well in bringing down population growth do not lose their seat share. This is fair federalism.

Upholding federalism

What the DemPer principle acknowledges is that States are meaningful political units, and that democracy is about fair voice, and not just raw numbers. Federal stability matters as much as electoral arithmetic. Applying DemPer to the Lok Sabha would balance democratic equality with federal fairness, reduce regional resentment, protect incentives for good governance, and improve the quality of representation without undermining legitimacy.

However, what is the ideal Lok Sabha size after expansion? The average population per seat in a State in 1971 was between 10 and 11.1 lakh. But then the total population of India was barely 541 million; it is now almost three times as large (1.4 billion). If India is to keep democracy vibrant with serious time allocated to deep debate, then the Lok Sabha size cannot be permitted to increase beyond 700.

Moreover, the delimitation exercise should no longer be seen as a north-south matter. A host of States across India, such as Punjab, Haryana, Himachal, Goa etc., had adopted the goal of containing their population, not just the southern States. Therefore, fair federalism is critical to the survival our Union.

Shielding ‘choice’ from ‘honour’

Karnataka’s anti-honour killing Bill protects and upholds the right to choose

STATE OF PLAY

Bageshree S.
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The Gujarat government recently proposed that couples who want to register their marriage would have to submit identity documents of their parents and declare that they have been kept informed. In contrast, the just-concluded Budget session of the Karnataka Legislature saw the passage of the Karnataka Freedom of Choice in Marriage and Prevention and Prohibition of Crimes in the Name of Honour and Tradition (Eva Nammava, Eva Nammava) Bill, 2026, which provides legal protection for couples in inter-caste relationships who face threats, violence or coercion from anyone, including their own family members.

The Bill pointedly states that “the consent of the person’s parents, family, caste or clan is not necessary once the two adult individuals agree to enter into a marriage.”

The debate about the need for a specific law to curb “honour”-related violence had gained traction in Karnataka following the gruesome killing of a pregnant 20-year-old by her father for marrying a Dalit man in the Inam Veerapur village in Hubballi taluk in north Karnataka in December, 2025. According to statistics provided by Home Minister G. Parameshwara to the House, Karnataka has witnessed 15 hate crimes against couples over the past five years.

A long fight

The phrase “Eva Nammava, Eva Nammava” in the title of the Bill harks back to a *vachana* of 12th-century philosopher-reformer Basavanna that

roughly translates as “Do not ask ‘who is he, who is he, who is he?’/ Say ‘he is ours, he is ours, he is ours’.” It contains a message of inclusivity from a reformer whose decision to facilitate a marriage between a Dalit man and a Brahmin woman led to intense social turmoil and violence.

The Bill notes “an alarming increase in violence, harassment, threats, and social ostracism – often perpetrated in the name of caste hierarchy, honour, custom – being directed against individuals, especially young couples, who exercise their right to marry.” It notes that such crimes disproportionately affects women, who are subjected to patriarchal control over their choices, and men from marginalised communities.

The stated aim of the Bill is not only “to affirm and protect the liberty, dignity, and autonomy of all persons, to prevent crimes committed in the name of ‘honour’ and tradition”, but also “to provide legal safeguards, remedies, and institutional mechanisms for prevention, redressal, and rehabilitation.”

The Bill proposes penalties, including a minimum five-year prison sentence for killings in the name of “honour”, while criminalising social boycotts linked to such cases. It provides for institutional support for couples, including police protection within six hours of receiving a complaint, esta-

blishment of state-funded safe houses in every district, and access to legal aid and assistance from non-governmental organisations.

It proposes creating a special cell for the prevention of crimes in the name of “honour” with a 24-hour helpline, Eva Nammava Vedike, in all districts to facilitate solemnisation of marriages, provide counselling services etc.

Lingering ambiguities

The specific provisions envisaged for the protection of couples in inter-caste relationships facing ostracisation or violence are undoubtedly welcome. But the question of how effectively they will be implemented remains, considering that crimes against such couples have continued despite existing laws. This question is even more pertinent when the spirit of the times seems more inclined to caste consolidation than annihilation – evident not just in the way we choose or are allowed to choose our life partners, but also in the way candidates are picked by political parties and chosen to be in power by the electorate.

Interestingly, while the new Bill to support inter-caste couples has been passed, Karnataka is yet to, despite Cabinet approval, roll back the controversial Karnataka Protection of Right to Freedom of Religion Act, 2022 (anti-conversion Act) ushered in by the previous Bharatiya Janata Party government. While this law with stringent provisions deals with a gamut of issues related to conversion, cases across India illustrate how it comes into sharp focus in the case of interfaith marriages (dubbed ‘love jihad’).

Surely, consenting adults in interfaith relationships facing hostility and violence also deserve support.

U.S.-Israel-Iran war puts India’s EV gap in focus

While both India and China rely on oil supplies from West Asia, China’s early EV adoption has made its transport sector less exposed to the fuel crisis

DATA POINT

Devvyanshi Bihani

The surge in global oil prices after the U.S.-Iran war has exposed the differing levels of energy vulnerability in Asia’s two largest economies, India and China. Since the conflict began on February 28, crude and refined fuel prices have increased rapidly, with the Organization of the Petroleum Exporting Countries (OPEC) basket price rising by about 67% between February 27 and March 27, pushing up petrol, diesel and LPG costs.

The rise in fuel costs has revived interest in alternatives such as Electric Vehicles (EVs), plug-in hybrids and electric two-wheelers, especially in countries that rely heavily on imported oil.

The war has also increased the risk of supply disruptions due to the closure of the Strait of Hormuz, through which about one-fifth of global oil supply normally passes. China received 5.4 million barrels of crude oil per day via the Strait in FY25Q1, the highest in volume. India followed at 2.1 million barrels per day. But while both countries depend on imported oil, China’s faster adoption of EVs has reduced its transport sector’s exposure to fuel shocks, whereas India’s transport sector remains heavily reliant on fossil fuels.

Data on EV penetration show the scale of the gap between the two countries. In March 2026 alone, new-energy vehicles accounted for about 52.9% of passenger car sales in China, according to estimates by the China Passenger Car Association, while in India, EVs made up only about 6% of new car registrations in 2026 (**Chart 1**).

Absolute sales numbers highlight the contrast. China sold about nine lakh new-energy passenger vehicles in March 2026 alone, whereas India registered about 72,000 electric cars in the last three months. In the two- and

three-wheeler segment, China sold more than 72 lakh electric vehicles in 2024, while India’s sales even in 2026 were only about 4.27 lakh (**Chart 2**).

Because China began electrification earlier, the total number of EVs in use is far larger. China’s electric car fleet had reached about 2.3 crore by 2024, compared with about 3.96 lakh in India in 2026. China had about 6.8 crore electric two- and three-wheelers in use, while India has about 23 lakh. Overall, India’s total EV stock stood at about 27.3 lakh, still far below China’s levels (**Chart 3**).

Infrastructure and supply chains also reflect the gap. As of February 2026, India has about 14 electric cars per public charger, compared with roughly nine in China by the end of 2025, indicating higher charging availability which has allowed China to push EV adoption faster in the passenger vehicle segment (**Chart 4**).

These differences have direct implications during oil crises. Countries with high EV adoption are less exposed to sudden increases in petrol and diesel prices because a larger share of transport runs on electricity.

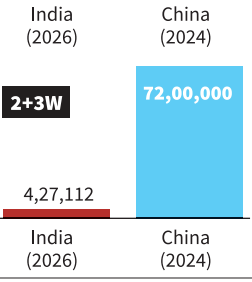
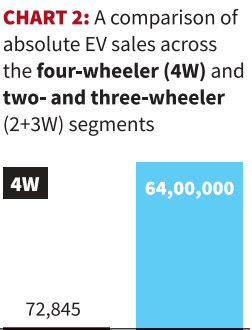
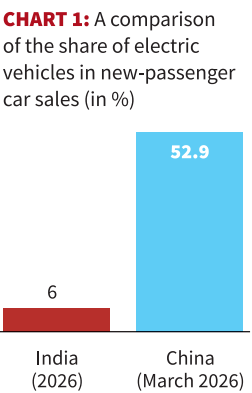
The recent increases in fuel price across several Asian countries following the Iran conflict have strengthened the argument for accelerating the transition to electric mobility. The shift is already visible in the market. *Bloomberg* recently reported that demand for EVs has increased across Asia after the Iran oil shock, with Chinese carmakers such as BYD seeing higher showroom traffic as consumers shift away from fossil fuel-driven vehicles.

India has made progress, especially in electric three-wheelers, but adoption in cars and buses remains low and charging infrastructure limited, compared to China. As long as petrol, diesel and LPG remain the backbone of transport, every geopolitical conflict in West Asia will continue to be felt directly in Indian households.

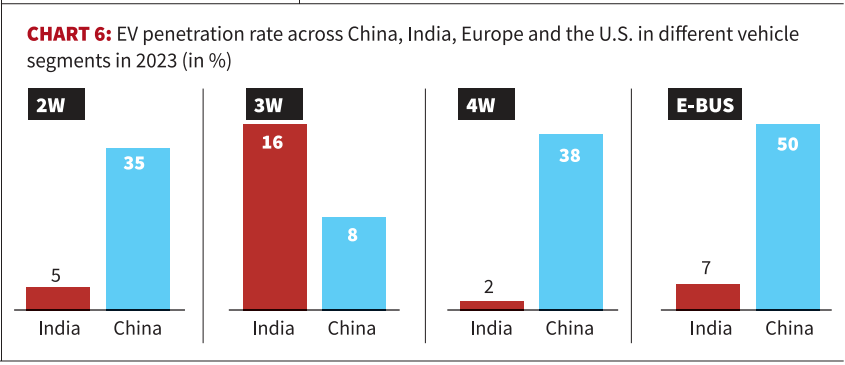
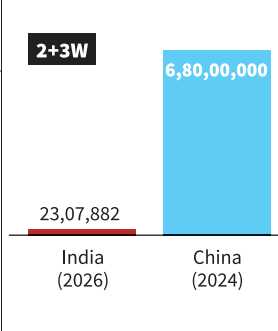
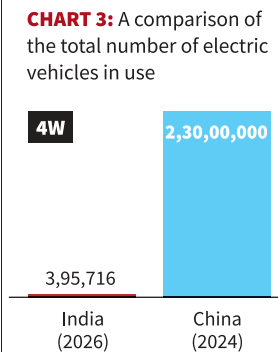
Electric gulf

China leads across the EV ecosystem with higher adoption, manufacturing, and charging infrastructure. India shows progress with respect to electric three-wheelers but faces gaps in scale, infrastructure, and supply chains

- 2W: Two-wheeler
- 3W: Three-wheeler
- 4W: Four-wheeler



Low voltage: An electric vehicle charging station at Freedom park in Bengaluru. ALLEN EGENUSE J.



FROM THE ARCHIVES

The **Hindu.**

FIFTY YEARS AGO MARCH 31, 1976

Indian wagon assembly unit in Iran favoured

New Delhi, March 30: Iran will be the best location for a railway wagon assembly plant to be set up for purposes of export orders, according to a project report written for the Union Ministry of Industry and Civil Supplies.

The report written by Wagon India (Private) Limited, New Delhi has estimated that the assembly unit can be set up in 24 months at a total capital cost of Rs. 343.58 lakhs with an assembly capacity of 5,000 four-wheel wagons and employing about 260 employees.

A limitation that the Government will have to face, if a decision is taken to go ahead with this project, is that Iran has already awarded a contract to Simmering Graz-Pauker of Austria, to design and construct a plan for production of 1,000 wagons per year. This plant is expected to go into operation in 1976.

“Implementation of this project,” says the report, “will not only affect the prospects of export of wagons to Iran but will also have to be kept in view while considering the location of an assembly plant in one of the countries in West Asia.”

The desirability of setting up a wagon assembly plant abroad began to engage the serious attention of the Heavy Industry Ministry, because of the very heavy freight incurred on the export of complete wagons.

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO MARCH 31, 1926

Through booking arrangements between India and Ceylon

Arrangements at present exist for through booking of goods and coaching traffic between stations on the South Indian Railway alone and stations on the Ceylon Government Railway.

Goods and coaching traffic from any stations in India other than those on the South Indian Railway to stations on the Ceylon Government Railway and vice versa, may, however, be booked to the Madura Co. Ltd. Dhanushkodi and the senders should make previous arrangements with them to re-book the traffic onward.

No responsibility will be accepted either by the South Indian or the Ceylon Government Railway in the matter of re-booking.

From Page One

Trump threatens Iran’s power sites over deal

The U.S. President said his administration is in talks with Iran to end the war, while the Pentagon is sending additional troops to the region. Iran has denied reports of negotiations and said it has got a proposal from Washington which is not acceptable. It has made its own counter-proposal.

“It is not clear how much, even inside the U.S., the country’s claims about diplomacy and negotiations are seriously taken into account,” Esmail Baghaei, spokesperson of Iran’s Ministry of Foreign Affairs, said about Mr. Trump’s claims about talks. “Reactions and reflections also show that the extent of global trust in the U.S. claims in the field of diplomacy is very limited.”

‘Tehran will determine the end’

Iran’s Khatam al-Anbiya Central Headquarters dismissed Mr. Trump’s threats and said Tehran “is the party that will determine the end” of the ongoing war. “Even though Trump, egoistically and mistakenly, initiated a military aggression against Iran along with the child-killing Zionist regime, he well knows that he will eventually be faced with the heroic and seasoned Iranian nation and its armed forces. This is why he has resorted to other world leaders to end the war,” military spokesman Ebrahim Zolfaqari said.

Iran and Israel continued to exchange fire on Monday, with the Israel Defence Forces (IDF) claiming to have struck weapons production sites in Iran.

The targets included a site where long-range anti-aircraft missiles are assembled, a manufacturing facility for components for anti-tank and anti-aircraft missiles, and a production and R&D site for ballistic missile engines, the IDF said. Israeli authorities said Iran carried out at least six missile attacks. An oil refinery in Haifa came under attack, causing a large blaze.

The Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps (IRGC) said they fired the 87th wave of attacks on Monday, targeting Israel and American bases in the region. According to an IRGC statement, the strikes targeted five U.S. bases in the region, as well as military positions in the southern, central and northern parts of Israel, including Haifa Bay, Kiryat Shmona, Tel Aviv, Be’er Sheva, Dimona, al-Kharj, Jufair and other locations.

Manufacturing, capital goods lift IIP to 5.2%

Notably, growth in the capital goods sector accelerated to a nine-month high of 12.5% in February 2026 from 4.1% in the previous month. This performance on the back of a relatively strong performance of 8.1% in February of last year.

Consumer demand, however, seems to have slumped, according to the data. The consumer durables sector contracted 2.1% in February 2026, the sector’s worst performance in 27 months. The consumer non-durables sector, too, contracted 0.6%, the second consecutive month of contraction.

“Overall, the data confirms that investment linked sectors are anchoring growth, while softer consumer non durables and modest mining and electricity gains highlight areas where the recovery is still incomplete,” Mr. Sharan said. “From a credit rating perspective, sustained manufacturing and investment momentum support credit strength, though uneven demand means fundamentals are still evolving.”

Delhi Police arrest LeT operative in poster case

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Special Cell of the Delhi Police has arrested a suspected Lashkar-e-Taiba (LeT) handler from Ghazipur area in Delhi, officials said on Monday.

Police said the arrest of Shabir Ahmed Lone came after they learnt about his connections with the “anti-India” posters in several Delhi metro stations on February 22.

Calling Lone a “hard-core and highly-trained terrorist”, the officials said that he reportedly established links with handlers operating on behalf of Inter-Services Intelligence.

“Lone, also known by aliases Raja and Kashmiri, is a resident of Srinagar in Jammu and Kashmir and was allegedly operating as the handler of a recently-busted module involved in pasting anti-national posters across multiple locations in Delhi and Kolkata,” a senior police officer said.

Opposition walks out as BJP MP alleges ‘misuse’ of OBC quota

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

BJP MP K. Laxman’s allegations that several States “misuse” the Other Backward Classes (OBC) quota by including Muslims in the category created an uproar in the Rajya Sabha, leading to a walkout by Opposition members.

Mr. Laxman alleged that States such as Karnataka, Tamil Nadu, West Bengal, Kerala and Telangana— all of them Opposition ruled— had extended OBC reservations to Muslim communities in violation of constitutional provisions.

He argued that the Constitution does not permit reservation on religious grounds.

“Unfortunately, reservations meant for socially and educationally backward OBCs are now being extended on the basis of religion,” he said.

Mr. Laxman claimed that such decisions were driven by “vote-bank polit-



K. Laxman

ics”, depriving genuinely backward communities of their rightful share.

Calling for a “comprehensive review” of what he termed “religion-based reservations”, Mr. Laxman urged the Centre to ensure that the principle of social and educational backwardness, not religious identity, remains the basis for affirmative action.

His speech was drowned in protests from the Opposition benches. When neither Mr. Laxman refused to concede the ground and Chairman C.P. Radhakrishnan also refused to allow the Opposition leaders to interject, so they staged a walkout.

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Lok Sabha on Monday witnessed a brief adjournment after the Opposition members insisted on a discussion on the West Asia crisis and its impact on India.

The issue was raised as soon as Zero Hour began at noon, with Congress member Manish Tewari urging the Chair to allow a discussion as there had been an escalation of hostilities between Iran and the U.S.-Israel combine.

“The Business Advisory Committee had discussed this issue. There should be a discussion on the situation in West Asia and the crisis with regard to LPG, crude oil, and fertilizers,” Mr. Tewari said.

After papers listed for the day were laid on the Table of the House, the Opposition members renewed their demand, leading to noisy scenes.

Responding to the protests, Parliamentary Affairs Minister Kiren Rijiju said



As protests from the Opposition continued, Speaker Om Birla adjourned the House for 15 minutes. ANI

the government was willing to discuss the matter with the Opposition. However, the Minister said it was important to discuss the issue of left-wing extremism (LWE) as Home Minister Amit Shah had declared that Maoist activities would end in the country by March 31, 2026.

He pointed out that Prime Minister Narendra Modi had already made a statement on the West Asia crisis in both Houses of Parliament.

Mr. Rijiju said that whenever a crisis arises, all sides should stand together and avoid politicising the issue. He also assured the House that the government was ready to work with the Opposition.

However, as the protests continued, Speaker Om Birla adjourned the House for 15 minutes.

What is the plan?

Speaking to reporters within the Parliament premises, Congress MP Priyanka

Gandhi Vadra said a discussion was required because the crisis might worsen in the coming days.

“As this war escalates, there are indications that the crisis is going to worsen. We want to discuss so that we can find out solutions. The prices of gas cylinders have gone up; there may be shortage of petrol, diesel. So, we need to know the government’s planning and together we should find solutions,” Ms. Vadra said.

Barring one, entire top leadership of Maoists wiped out from country, Shah tells Lok Sabha

Vijaita Singh
NEW DELHI

Union Home Minister Amit Shah said on Monday that barring one, the entire leadership of Maoists had been wiped out in the past two years.

He said that at the beginning of 2024, there were 21 politburo and central committee members of the Communist Party of India (Maoists) but as of today, one was arrested, seven surrendered, 12 were killed, and dialogue is on with the absconding member who is expected to surrender soon.

“Thus, their politburo and central structure have been almost completely dismantled. Our goal was a Naxal-free India by March 31. The country will be informed once the entire



Union Home Minister Amit Shah speaks in the Lok Sabha during the Budget Session of Parliament on Monday. ANI

process is formally completed, but I can say that we have become Naxal-free,” Mr. Shah said, while replying to a discussion on Maoism in the Lok Sabha.

In the past three years, 706 Maoists were killed, 2,218 were arrested, and more than 4,800 cadres have surrendered.

Attacking the then Congress-led UPA government, he said the police and Central Armed Police Forces personnel were there before 2014 as well but what changed was clear policy and strong political will.

He said dialogue and discussion was futile with some people and force had

to be used against them. “They planted bombs in farmers’ fields, crippling them... I have said it many times – lay down arms, complete arrangements for rehabilitation will be made but a bullet will be answered with a bullet.”

Mr. Shah said 12 States had become part of the Red Corridor (belt affected by Maoism) and there was no rule of law there.

Three tools

In the fight against left-wing extremism (LWE) three tools – dialogue, security, and coordination – were deployed, he said. “By using the latest technology, we carried out precise surveillance and analysed a large volume of telephone bills. With the help of location-tracking systems, mobile phone ac-

BJD slams remarks on Biju Patnaik by BJP MP Nishikant

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Biju Janata Dal president Naveen Patnaik on Monday said BJP MP Nishikant Dubey must consult a doctor for making “outrageous” remarks against freedom fighter and former Odisha Chief Minister Biju Patnaik.

Mr. Dubey, in a statement on March 27, had claimed that Biju Patnaik was the “link” between former Prime Minister Jawaharlal Nehru and U.S. foreign intelligence service CIA during the war against China in the 1960s.

“I am surprised to find the outrageous things that Mr. Nishikant Dubey said about Biju Babu. I do not think that Jawaharlal Nehru had put an office next to his in Delhi, while Biju Babu was still the Chief Minister of Odisha, to plan tactics and fight the Chinese,” Mr. Patnaik told reporters outside the State Assembly in Bhubaneswar.

RS walkout

The BJD also staged a walkout in the Rajya Sabha in protest. BJD floor leader Sasmit Patra rose to speak



Naveen Patnaik

soon after the session convened for the day. “The BJD does not disturb the House. But today we want to place on record our serious protest against the disparaging, false and concocted statements made by MP Nishikant Dubey against Biju Patnaik. He called Biju Patnaik a CIA agent. This is the extent to which the ruling party has fallen. This is shameful,” he said.

Mr. Dubey posted on X that he had been seeking to expose the “misdeeds of the Congress” and not Biju Patnaik. “When the Congress did injustice to Biju Babu, it was the Jan Sangh and the BJP which stood by him. Tell me, which allegation did I level against Biju Babu in my tweet?,” he wrote.



JD(U) MLC Sanjay Gandhi displays resignation letter of Bihar CM Nitish Kumar. PTI

Nitish resigns as MLC, Nabin as MLA after move to RS

Amarnath Tewary
PATNA

Bihar Chief Minister Nitish Kumar and BJP president Nitin Nabin on Monday resigned from the membership of the Bihar Legislative Council and Assembly, respectively. Both leaders are likely to take oath as newly elected members of the Rajya Sabha on April 10.

With Mr. Kumar’s resignation, all eyes are now set on who would be the next Chief Minister of Bihar. Rashtriya Janata Dal (RJD) leader Tejashwi Yadav, who is also Leader of the Opposition in the State Assembly, took a jibe over Mr. Kumar’s resignation and said he had not resigned but was “removed and deceived” by the BJP.

Mr. Kumar’s resignation letter was accepted by Council chairman Awadhesh Narayan Singh and Mr. Nabin’s resignation was accepted by Assembly Speaker Prem Kumar.

Mr. Nabin, who had been the MLA for Bankipur for five terms, was away from Patna and had sent his resignation letter to the Speaker through BJP State president Sanjay Sarangi. Mr. Nabin posted a message on social media on his political journey as an MLA from the constituency which, earlier, was represented by his late father Nabin Kishore Prasad Sinha for four terms.

Mr. Kumar and Mr. Nabin were elected to the Rajya Sabha on March 16. According to Constitutional provisions, the two leaders were supposed to step down from the State legislature within 14 days.

Opposition says Bill will demoralise CAPF, BJP defends draft legislation

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Echoing the concerns of senior non-IPS officers in the Central Armed Police Forces, the Opposition argued in the Rajya Sabha on Monday that the CAPF (General Administration) Bill went against constitutional values and principles of natural justice and demanded that it be sent to a Select Committee for examination.

BJP leaders said the Bill is an example of the fact that the government stands with its paramilitary forces and that, unlike in the past, there are structured provisions in the Bill for promotions for an officer who joins as Assistant Commandant.

BJP MP Sudhanshu Trivedi said at the Deputy Inspector General level, there would be no reservation for officers from the IPS cadre and officers who join as Assistant Commandants can become DIGs. “50% officers can reach up



CAPF personnel have flagged career stagnation because of the deputation of IPS officers in the forces. ANI

to Inspector General level and one-third of the officers can be posted at Additional Director General level,” he said, adding that the Bill offers a clear structure for promotions.

“It is not true to say that the Bill will have impact on the morale of the CAPF,” Mr. Trivedi said. “Four or five promotions will be available to officers of all strata,” he added.

Lawyer and Congress MP Vivek Tankha said the Bill lacked a purpose. “What was the necessity of

this umbrella Bill when officers are not interested in deputation and about 18 posts of IGs are vacant in the forces?” he asked.

Mr. Tankha said as an organised force, the CAPF officers were asking equal treatment and courts had agreed on this demand.

“This Bill is to negate the Supreme Court judgement and it will not succeed,” he said, adding that the Centre was trying to nullify a court order. “I don’t think the Law Ministry has vetted this Bill,” he

said, noting that the provisions were against at least two orders of the Supreme Court.

“This Bill is for demoralising the force,” Mr. Tankha said.

Supreme Court cases

DMK MP Tiruchi Siva said the provisions of the Bill went against remarks made by Prime Minister Narendra Modi in 2019 that anomalies in the CAPF structures would be addressed and the Supreme Court guidance accepted.

“In May 2025, the Supreme Court very clearly gave a judgement that slowly, within two years, the Home Ministry should phase out the deputation of IPS officers in the CAPF and enable their own officers reach those rank. However, Clause 3(i) of this Bill says that IPS deputation is a must and you [the government] are insisting upon that. Are the CAPF officers incompetent to lead their own teams?” Mr. Siva asked.

Assam CM flays claim of 'justice' for Zubeen

Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma on Monday questioned the Congress promise of fast justice to cultural icon Zubeen Garg, if voted to power. "Justice can be delivered only by the courts, not by political leaders within 10, 30, or even 100 days. Our government did its job by filing chargesheets and

putting the accused behind bars," he said. "Do they (Congress) want me to put a gun to the judge's head to deliver justice?" he asked, pointing out that no government can interfere in judicial proceedings. The Chief Minister said if Congress can deliver justice so fast, it should not have taken years in the case of former Prime Minister Rajiv Gandhi's assassination. "Justice is a legal process and cannot be rushed for political gains," he added.



'Justice can be delivered only by the courts', says Himanta Biswa Sarma

Poll duty for forest officials invites flak

A group of retired Indian Administrative Service, Indian Forest Service officials and wildlife conservationists has raised "serious concerns" over the Assam government deploying around 1,600 personnel of the Assam Forest Protection Force (AFFP) on election duty. An Assam government

official confirmed to *The Hindu* that it was the "first time" forest personnel were requisitioned for election duty. In a joint representation to authorities on March 28, the signatories have argued that the order dated March 19, 2026, violates both election guidelines and a binding Supreme Court directive. The signatories said Election Commission of India's norms do not allow the deployment of territorial forest staff for election work.



BJP is stoking a fight among all sections of society. It wants to loot the country, taking advantage of situations evolving from such strife
MAMATA BANERJEE
West Bengal CM

PCI advises media to refrain from exit polls

The Press Council of India (PCI) has advised media to adhere to the rules on "exit polls". "No person shall conduct any exit poll and publish or publicise by means of the print or electronic media or disseminate in any other manner, whatsoever, the result of any exit poll..." it said in a release.



We can see a new confidence among people today as the BJP's double-engine government has made every effort for peace in Assam
NARENDRA MODI
Prime Minister



Congress candidate Gaurav Gogoi during a rally in Jorhat on March 23. ANI

The political does not get personal in campaign in parts of Assam

Rahul Karmakar
JORHAT

The 2026 Assembly election in Assam have often turned verbally acrimonious, with candidates threatening their rivals or using inappropriate language. But a few are standing out for their civility by striking a courteous note. Jorhat – known as Assam's "tea capital" and the fountainhead of Assamese intellectual and literary greats – is one such constituency. The others include Dispur, New Guwahati, and north-western Assam's Tamulpur.

It is not unusual for younger candidates in these constituencies to touch the feet of their elder rivals, praise each other's oratorical skills, or exchange pleasantries and hug each other during face-to-face interactions. "Jorhat has among the highest literacy rates in Assam, and people here are generally well behaved. They do not tolerate abusive or aggressive language. This reflects in the leaders they elect," local environment activist Biju Sarma said.

'Criticism need not be disrespectful'

The Bharatiya Janata Party's Hitendra Nath Goswami, 67, is seeking re-election from Jorhat. His main rival is 43-year-old State Congress president Gaurav Gogoi, who currently represents the Jorhat Lok Sabha seat. "My younger rival speaks well, but that does not mean his victory is guaranteed," said Mr. Goswami, who has a law degree in addition to a Master's in science, adding that political criticism need not be disrespectful. Mr. Gogoi, who holds a Master's degree in public administration from New York University, returned the courtesy, wishing his BJP rival well but asserting, "Jorhat is yearning for a change."

Candidates in Guwahati

In Guwahati, more than 300 km west, Independent candidate Jayanta Kumar Das, 57, admitted that he has an axe to grind with his former party, the BJP, but not with his "gentleman" rival, former Congress MP Pradyut Bordoloi, 65. The two are in a triangular contest along with Congress candidate Mira Borthakur Goswami in Dispur. In the adjoining New Guwahati, Congress candidate Santanu Borah, 44, and the BJP's Dipu Ranjan Sarmah, 50, said they would work together for the development of the constituency, irrespective of the outcome.

Development agendas in focus

A similar vibe prevails in north-western Assam's Tamulpur, one of the 15 constituencies under the Bodoland Territorial Council (BTC). Instead of targeting each other or their parties, the top two contestants—Assembly Speaker Biswajit Daimary of the BJP and United People's Party Liberal (UPPL) president Pramod Boro—have been concentrating on development agendas. "Our upbringing does not allow us to be rude or indulge in personal attack. As public representatives, it is our responsibility to set a good example," said Mr. Boro, 51, an elected member of the BTC and a Rajya Sabha member-elect. Mr. Daimary, 52, concurred.

'UDF began preparations for Mission 2026 a year ago; it will win in Kerala'

The Leader of the Opposition says the Congress has brought back 90% of the social groups that left the UDF; he says the LDF government has pushed State into a 'huge debt trap' and 'failed in the health, education, agriculture and welfare sectors' due to which there is a current against the government

INTERVIEW

V.D. Satheesan

K.S. Sudhi

V.D. Satheesan, the Leader of the Opposition in Kerala, is confident that the United Democratic Front (UDF) will storm back to power in Kerala after 10 years, riding on the Congress's organisational preparedness and a groundswell of support. He reiterates that he would quit politics if the UDF does not win the Kerala polls. Edited excerpts:

After being in the Opposition for 10 years, it is a do-or-die situation for the Congress in Kerala. How prepared is the party?

It was a difficult situation for us as we lost twice in a row. As the party leaders and workers were demoralised, the first duty was to boost their morale. Generally, those in the Opposition often lose byelections. However, in Kerala, we have been winning those by huge margins. We posted impressive victories in the parliamentary election and the civic polls. We began the prepara-

tions for Mission 2026 one year ago. We succeeded in bringing 90% of the social groups that had left the United Democratic Front (UDF). Now, the UDF is not just a confederation of political parties, but a broader political platform with political parties, opinion-makers, social groups, and even Left fellow-travellers on board.

Earlier, there were several groups in the party fighting each other. Now, it is all over, and no group has any dominance over the party. We have a collective leadership where we discuss issues, make decisions and implement them. At the same time, the CPI(M) is faced with internal rebellion and a large number of leaders have left the party. The CPI(M) is disintegrating in Kerala as it happened in West Bengal and Tripura.

While submitting a chargesheet against the government, we have put forward alternative programmes and projects. We have come up with proposals to improve the health and education sectors after holding conclaves. We are approaching the people with specific plans and projects to address the issues faced by the State.

What is the ground



THULASI KAKKAT

situation? Is there a groundswell in favour of the UDF?

There is a huge anti-incumbency sentiment against the government. A major section of society is against the government. Many Left fellow-travellers now openly say that there should not be any continuity in the government as they fear that such a situation will destroy the party.

The lives of people have become miserable. Kerala is the number one State in terms of price rise, and there was no market intervention to arrest the price rise. This was the most inefficient government Kerala has ever seen.

What do you think are the three failures of the government?

First, it is the fiscal situation. Kerala is in a huge

debt trap. The government mismanaged the financial situation. It has also failed in the health, education, agriculture and welfare sectors. Third, it is the gold pilferage in Sabarimala. Three senior leaders of the CPI(M) were arrested in the case. The office of the Chief Minister is putting pressure on the Special Investigation Team (SIT) constituted by the Kerala High Court. The SIT could not even file a preliminary charge sheet in the case.

All the accused are out on statutory bail and are busy removing the evidence. Though three of its senior leaders were arrested in the case, the CPI(M) has not taken any disciplinary action against them fearing that they may reveal the names and role of some Ministers or former Ministers in the case.

In the past 10 years,

Congress could send fewer than 25 legislators to the Assembly. You need to at least double it to try to come back to power.

The party's efforts to bring back the social groups to its fold will have an impact and bring good results. The return of the social groups, the anti-incumbency factor and the organisational preparations will help the party improve its performance.

Even while the Congress is pinning its hopes on the anti-incumbency factor, the CPI(M) has fielded more than 50 of its sitting MLAs, which many feel is a reflection of its confidence in the work it has done.

The fielding of the sitting MLAs need not bring the desired results. The popularity of the MLAs need not translate into poll results. Popularity may work in some individual cases. But they may not survive the general trend.

It is being said that the BJP is preparing itself for the 2031 elections and hopes to eat into the vote base of the Congress. The BJP has also succeeded in

winning over some Congress and Left leaders to its side.

The BJP had been unsuccessfully trying this since 2005. However, their vote share dropped in the recent civic polls. The BJP has entered into a deal with the CPI(M) to beat the Congress. There could be a triangular fight in five or six seats. It is a direct fight between the LDF and the UDF in the rest of the seats.

Even while being part of the INDIA bloc, the Congress and CPI(M) are fighting each other in Kerala. Recently, Congress leader Rahul Gandhi and Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan were highly critical of each other.

It was the Chief Minister who started abusing Mr. Gandhi and he even went to the extent of calling Congress the 'B' team of the BJP. Mr. Gandhi is one person who has been fighting the BJP's communalism.

You have stated that you would go to political exile if you cannot bring Congress back to power.

Yes. If I cannot bring the UDF back to power, I will definitely quit politics.

Rangasamy, Puducherry's longest-serving Chief Minister and ace strategist, in race for fifth term

M. Dinesh Varma
PUDUCHERRY

Through the ups and downs of a political career spanning over three decades, four-time Chief Minister and All India NR Congress (AINRC) founder N. Rangasamy remains a force to reckon with in Puducherry politics, as the 75-year-old prepares to lead the National Democratic Alliance's campaign for re-election in the April 9 Assembly polls.

The law graduate began his political journey in the Congress in the late 1980s. He went on to become the longest-serving CM of the Union Territory, holding office for over 16 years and earning the epithet, "*Makkal Mudhalvar*" (CM of the masses).

Mr. Rangasamy is a known admirer of the welfare agenda of former Tamil Nadu CM K. Kamaraj. Once at a vintage car rally, he excitedly entered a restored Chevrolet Master Deluxe on coming to know that it once seated the pioneer of the mid-day meal scheme in schools.

He has served as Chief Minister twice each as Congress leader and AINRC supremo. In his current term as Chief Minister, he has been criticised by opponents of only paying lip ser-



Battle hardened: N. Rangasamy is the longest-serving Chief Minister of Puducherry, having held office for 16 years. PTI

Rangasamy held his ground in the NDA, blocking the creation of a Deputy CM post for the BJP

vice to the long-felt aspiration for Statehood. The NDA government was also rocked by allegations of corruption in the issuing of distillery licences, a temple land grab case that led to arrests of government officials, and the expose of a fake drug manufacturing scam with nationwide ramifications.

Mr. Rangasamy has also found himself up against the BJP in having his way in certain administrative matters, often complaining of working with "his hands tied", in a veiled reference to alleged overreach by the Lok Nivas. On some occa-

sions, he held his ground too, from blocking the precedent of creating a Deputy CM post for the BJP, to preserving his prerogative to determine Cabinet berths.

Mr. Rangasamy's political journey didn't start on an easy note. His electoral debut in 1990 culminated in a defeat when he narrowly lost to Janata Dal candidate V. Pethaperumal in the election to the Thattanchavady Assembly constituency.

During this low point, Mr. Rangasamy, on a friend's advice, sought the blessings of a seer in Salem, Appa Paithiyam Swamy. It is said that the guru convinced him to remain in politics, predicting a bright future. In a change of luck since, Mr. Rangasamy saw a string of victories from the same seat.

Mr. Rangasamy was sworn in as the Congress CM for the first time in 2001, becoming the first person from the influential Vanniyar community to occupy the top post.

The Thattanchavady constituency, which he went on to cultivate as a personal fiefdom - so much so that at one point, critics dubbed him the "CM of Thattanchavady" - would continue to play a pivotal role in his political fortunes. Incidentally, it was the very constituency that pitchforked him to the CM's chair for a record fourth term after the 2021 elections.

In his second tenure as CM in 2006, serious strife in the Cabinet and differences with colleagues who accused him of diverting all development projects to Thattanchavady at the cost of other Assembly segments, culminated in his ouster in 2008.

Mr. Rangasamy remained aloof from the Congress since the ignominy. He later stepped down as MLA and told the media that he took the decision owing to his displeasure at "the way the government treated my constituency".

Just months before the 2011 Assembly election, Mr. Rangasamy formed his own party, the AINRC,

which romped home, winning 15 of the 17 seats it contested. He went on to form the government with the support of one Independent, cold-shouldering alliance partner, the AIADMK. For a long while since then, the AIADMK nursed a grudge against Mr. Rangasamy for what former Tamil Nadu CM Jayalalithaa termed in 2011 as "betrayal" - for reneging on a pre-poll power-sharing promise.

This was hardly the only time that political circles got a sense of the shrewd, calculating politician behind the mild-mannered, man-of-simplicity demeanour. Once, when he faced dissidence from his party MLAs to his nominee for a Rajya Sabha vacancy while serving as CM in 2015, he didn't bat an eyelid in having the candidate hastily inducted into the AIADMK and elected to the Upper House - a win-win for Mr. Rangasamy, who quelled the rebellion, and for the AIADMK, which pounced on the chance to deny arch rival, the DMK, a chance to field an Independent candidate with the support of a faction of the ruling party and the Congress.

A master political strategist or rank opportunist? The response depends on who you ask.

BJP seeks action against Mamata over 'MCC breach'

Devesh K. Pandey
NEW DELHI

The Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) on Monday urged the Election Commission of India (EC) to initiate legal proceedings and prohibit West Bengal Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee from participating in the election campaign for alleged violations of the Model Code of Conduct (MCC) in the State.

A delegation comprising Union Ministers Piyush Goyal, Kiren Rijiju, and Sukanta Majumdar, and BJP leaders Arun Singh, Anil Baluni, and Om Pathak submitted the complaint at the EC headquarters.

The party, in its complaint, accused Ms. Banerjee of making "grave and disturbing public statements" during multiple public rallies, reflecting "a consistent and alarming and ominous pattern of provocation, voter intimidation, and implicit incitement to violence..."

It alleged that on March 25, at a rally in north Bengal's Mainaguri, the Chief Minister reportedly said that after the polls get over, citizens would be compelled to display posters outside their homes declaring "I don't support BJP".

INBRIEF



West Asia conflict: 8 Indians killed in ‘various incidents’

Amid the escalating West Asia conflict, the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) on Monday said eight Indian nationals have lost their lives while one remains missing in “various incidents” in the region. At an inter-ministerial briefing in New Delhi on the West Asia situation, Additional Secretary (Gulf), MEA, Aseem R. Mahajan (in picture), also said, “Yesterday, an Indian national unfortunately lost his life in an attack in Kuwait.” However, he did not elaborate upon the circumstances of this death. Mr. Mahajan said the safety, security and welfare of the large Indian community in the region remain “our utmost priority”.

Govt. retains interest rates on small savings schemes

The Union government on Monday left interest rates unchanged for various small savings schemes, including PPF and NSC, for the eighth straight quarter, beginning April 1, 2026. As per a Finance Ministry notification, the Sukanya Samridhhi Scheme will attract an interest rate of 8.2%, while the rate on a three-year term deposit remains at 7.1%. The interest rates for Public Provident Fund (PPF), National Savings Certificate (NSC) and post office savings deposit schemes have been retained at 7.1%, 7.7% and 4%, respectively. The government last changed the interest rate on some schemes in the fourth quarter of the financial year 2023-24.

Centre eyes new regulation to cover social media users

It plans to amend IT Rules and allow I&B Ministry to send takedown notices to individual users for posts; Internet Freedom Foundation calls it ‘massive expansion of unconstitutional censorship’

Aroon Deep
NEW DELHI

The Union government is planning to allow the Ministry of Information and Broadcasting (I&B) to send takedown notices to individual users for their social media posts. Under the IT Rules, 2021, the Ministry could issue such notices only to on-line news platforms.

In addition, any advisories to social media platforms by the Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology would, if not complied with, affect the firms’ so-called “safe harbour”, allowing them to be held liable in court for users’ content.

These changes have been put forth in a draft amendment on Monday to the Information Technology (Intermediary Guidelines and Digital Media Ethics Code) Rules, 2021, which were amended as recently as February.

In an explanatory memorandum to the proposed amendment, the IT Ministry said that the addition of individual user posts was a “[c]larification of applicability” of those rules to “news and current affairs



The amendments are clarificatory and procedural in nature and are intended to improve legal certainty, strengthen enforceability of Ministry directions, and ensure effective oversight of intermediary-hosted content, particularly news and current affairs

MINISTRY OF ELECTRONICS AND INFORMATION TECHNOLOGY

content hosted by non-publisher users”.

In a statement, Internet Freedom Foundation (IFF), an Indian digital rights advocacy organisation, decried the proposal as a “massive expansion of unconstitutional censorship and regulatory power”.

The Ministry said these “amendments are clarificatory and procedural in nature and are intended to improve legal certainty, strengthen enforceability of Ministry directions, and ensure effective oversight of intermediary-hosted content, particularly news and current affairs.”

IFF pushed back on that claim, pointing to a key change in the proposal - an inter-departmental committee (IDC) to hear ap-

peals against complaint outcomes, which broadened its mandate. “The original Rule 14(2) required the IDC to hear “complaints regarding violation or contravention of the Code of Ethics.” “The amended version removes this requirement entirely.The IDC now hears: (a) grievances arising from decisions at Level I or II; or (b) “matters” referred to by the Ministry.”

The government uses Section 79 of the IT Act, under which the IT Rules were notified, to warn social media platforms that content under a takedown notice, if retained, would lead to the loss of their safe harbour. Since February’s amendment abruptly changed takedown time-

lines to retain safe harbour to two-three hours from 24-36 hours, Meta has been taking down more posts and accounts under such notices. Blocking orders that are more legally binding are issued under Section 69A.

IFF accused the Centre of trying to sidestep orders by the Madras and Bombay High Courts, which have stayed certain parts of the IT Rules. “The cumulative effect of the amendments to Rules 8 and 14 is to reconstruct the oversight machinery that the Bombay and Madras High Courts found constitutionally suspect, in a form designed to evade the interim orders,” IFF said.

Several notices

The government has been increasingly issuing broad takedown orders in the past few weeks against posts and accounts that are anti-establishment, and ones that mocked Prime Minister Narendra Modi. Asked about the recent spurt in takedowns, IT Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw said that the Centre was targeting “AI-generated deepfakes” and “fake news”.

India, Russia hold consultations amid crisis in West Asia

Kallol Bhattacharjee
NEW DELHI

Against the backdrop of the ongoing U.S.-Israel conflict with Iran, Indian and Russian diplomats held a round of Foreign Office Consultations here on Monday. The meeting came days after Russian Foreign Minister Sergei Lavrov said Moscow was working on the annual India-Russia summit to be held later this year in Russia.

During Monday’s consultations, the Russian delegation was headed by Deputy Foreign Minister Andrey Rudenko, while the Indian side was led by Foreign Secretary Vikram Misri. “Both sides reviewed the full spectrum of Special and Privileged Strategic Partnership and shared perspectives on bilateral, regional and global issues of mutual interest,” Ministry of External Affairs spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal said. A Russian Embassy readout said the two sides “discussed a wide range of issues on the bilateral agenda, including the schedule of upcoming contacts (planned interactions)”.

Later in the evening, Mr. Rudenko met External Af-



Andrey Rudenko with Vikram Misri in New Delhi.

fairs Minister S. Jaishankar and discussed “regional and global developments”.India is the current chair of BRICS, which includes Russia and India among its founding members.

The grouping has not come out with a statement even as the U.S.-Israel attacks on Iran have prompted the Islamic Republic to hit the U.S. military bases and energy interests in the United Arab Emirates and Saudi Arabia, increasing complications for the BRICS as Saudi Arabia, Iran and the UAE are members of the bloc.

On March 23, Mr. Jaishankar said “evolving multipolar world” calls for closer cooperation between the two countries, “through BRICS, SCO, G20 and the United Nations”.

GRSE delivers three frontline warships to Indian Navy

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Three frontline naval platforms – *INS Dunagiri*, *INS Sanshodhak*, and *INS Agray* – were delivered to the Navy on Monday by Garden Reach Shipbuilders and Engineers Ltd. (GRSE), marking a significant boost to India’s indigenous defence manufacturing capabilities under the *Aatmanirbhar Bharat* initiative.

This is the first time GRSE has delivered three major naval platforms simultaneously, underscoring its enhanced production capacity, improved project management, and operational efficiency. With this, the shipyard has now built 118 warships, including 80 for the Indian Navy, reinforcing its role as a key pillar of India’s maritime defence ecosystem.

Webinar on careers in semiconductor and electronics on April 3

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

As part of the Career Path Series, the Vellore Institute of Technology (VIT), Vellore, in collaboration with *The Hindu Education Plus*, will host a webinar titled “Electronic & Semiconductor Careers: Skills, Roles & How to Get Started” on April 3 at 4 p.m.

The webinar is aimed at helping students and young professionals navigate the evolving landscape of electronics and semiconductor innovation by providing a comprehensive overview of opportunities in the industry.

The session will provide guidance on how candidates can effectively start and build their careers in this field, while shedding light on emerging trends and the growing significance of semiconductor



technologies in shaping the future of industries.

The panel will feature experts, including Kanchana Bhaaskaran, Vice-Chancellor, VIT, Vellore; Sivantham Sathasivam, Director, VIT, Vellore; Abhishek Chaudhary, DFT engineer at Advanced Micro Devices, Inc.; and Abhirami R, staff engineer at Samsung Semiconductor India Research, Bengaluru.

To register, visit: <https://newsth.live/THVITESE>



Earliest Census data set to be available in 2027; India has fewer villages than during Census 2011

Vijaita Singh
NEW DELHI

As Census 2027 is being conducted digitally, most of the data gathered during the process will be published in 2027, Mritunjay Kumar Narayan, Registrar-General and Census Commissioner of India, said on Monday.

He said the caste enumeration methodology for the second phase was yet to be finalised, and officials were studying multiple suggestions received on the subject.

Data shared by Census officials show that compared with Census 2011, there has been a decrease in the number of villages by over 1,000 and an increase in urban settlements – statutory towns and Census towns.

From Census 2011, the number of States and Union Territories increased



Mritunjay Kumar Narayan, and Biswajit Das (Left) addressing the media on Census 2027 in New Delhi on Monday. SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA

by one to 36; districts from 640 to 784, an increase of 144; sub-districts by 1,102 – from 5,990 to 7,092; statutory towns by 1,087 – from 4,041 to 5,128; and census towns by 688 – from 3,892 to 4,580. The number of villages declined by 1,030, from 6,40,932 in 2011 to 6,39,902, according to the administrative unit data presented by the

Commissioner.

Mr. Narayan said West Bengal was the only State that had not notified the Census process, and while deliberations were on with the State government, it had time till September 30 to carry out the exercise.

This would be the first digital Census, first to enumerate caste and first to allow a self-enumeration option to respondents. The

data keyed in during self-enumeration would be verified by enumerators during door-to-door visit and the option was only available for residents living in India, he said, allaying concerns of data manipulation.

“As per the Census Act 1948, the Census data are confidential and the respondents are to answer to the best of their knowledge. Only aggregate data is released, an individual’s data cannot be shared with States or even the judiciary and do not also come under the purview of the Right to Information Act (RTI). Census data cannot be used to provide reservation benefits to any individual,” Mr. Narayan said, while addressing a press conference before the first phase of Census kicks off on April 1 in certain States. He said Census data were beyond the “scope of

investigation.”

16 languages

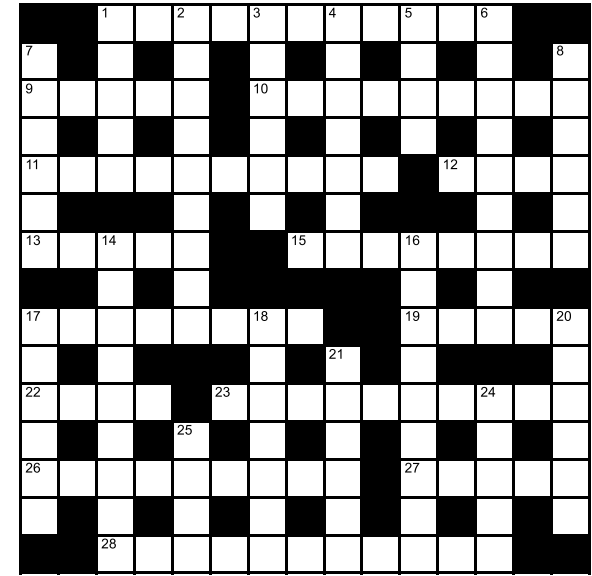
Mr. Narayan said the self-enumeration portal, available in 16 languages, would be live from April 1 to 15 for residents of the Andaman and Nicobar Islands, Goa, Karnataka, Sikkim, Odisha, Lakshadweep, Mizoram and the NDMC and Delhi Cantonment areas. Self-enumeration option would be available 15 days before the first phase of Census – the House Listing Operations (HLO) begins. The window for the first phase is April 1-September 30 for all States. The second phase – population enumeration where each individual’s information in the household, such as religion, caste etc. would be asked, would be conducted in February 2027.

“People can use mobile phones and laptop to fill in the data,” he said.

THE CROSSWORD+ 14755
(set by Incognito)

Solve this puzzle online and access more puzzles at <https://thehindu.com/crosswords>

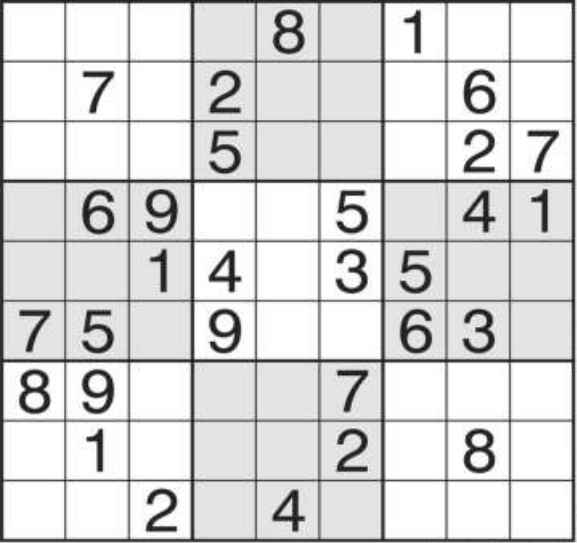
SCAN TO PLAY



- Across**
- 1 Metal worker at emergency room seen running amok shivers (11)
 - 9 Admit, "Won wrongly by state" (3,2)
 - 10 About the dog on call... It's happening again (9)
 - 11 Writing materials, for example, got from place where trains stop on Eastern Railway (10)
 - 12 Kind of hairstyle foreman may give when men leave (4)

- 13 Big animal? Also, small animal! (5)
 - 15 At American state surrounding Indiana (8)
 - 17 Stopped darters running around end of lane (8)
 - 19 Elector's veto changed with right (5)
 - 22 Butt-less Sten model? Let it stand! (4)
 - 23 Boy returned after vehicle is initially exploded with a piece of dynamite and destroyed (10)
 - 26 Butcher's guffaw (9)
 - 27 Governs in Maseru, Lesotho (5)
 - 28 Extraordinary ram astounds a seer, perhaps (11)
- Down**
- 1 Christmas visitor in Hassan taluk (5)
 - 2 Incercerates scamps covering Rhode Island issue (9)
 - 3 Birds starting to settle after Rhone redevelopment (6)
 - 4 Documents Engineers with ropes (7)
 - 5 Lug north and make money (4)
 - 6 Hide stone for a miser (9)
 - 7 Broth and shorba endlessly stirred after putting in a bit of cabbage (6)
 - 8 Pass over rebellious region (6)
 - 14 Clip-on ear manufactured for China (9)
 - 16 On value got from rewriting love drama (2,7)
 - 17 Help animal first (6)
 - 18 Old thespian becomes extortionist (7)
 - 20 Academician gets plate for vegetable (6)
 - 21 Loved advertisement... Love colour (6)
 - 24 Sailors may be made to smell these when unconscious (5)
 - 25 Times I'm excluded from images (4)

SUDOKU



Solution to previous puzzle

Solution to yesterday's Sudoku

FAITH

Advaita philosophy

Advaita Vedanta, a profound philosophical system established by Sri Adi Sankaracharya, teaches the principle of non-duality. Its central doctrine asserts that there exists only one ultimate reality, known as Brahman. This reality is infinite, formless and beyond all attributes. According to this philosophy, the individual self (Atman) is not different from Brahman; both are essentially one and the same.

A key concept in Advaita is Maya – the illusion that makes the world appear diverse and separate. This illusion, rooted in ignorance (Avidya), prevents individuals from realising the underlying unity of existence. Sri Kanchi Mahaswamy has lucidly explained the concept of Advaita philosophy, making it understandable even to a layman through various examples.

In a discourse, Smt. Desa Mangaiyarkarasi illustrated that when a person is asleep and dreaming, he may experience various situations – pleasant or unpleasant, joyful or distressing. These experiences feel real within the dream. However, upon waking, the individual recognises that the dream was merely an illusion, and their perception changes entirely. This analogy is used to explain the nature of reality. Just as the dream appears real until one awakens, the world appears divided and separate due to ignorance. In truth, there is only one unified existence. Similarly, there may be various ornaments in different shapes, sizes, and forms, but the common thing in all of them is the gold.

The concept of realising this oneness is not immediate. It requires time, deep understanding, and consistent practice.

IN BRIEF

IRDAI has approved amendments mandating insurers to prepare and present financial statements in accordance with applicable Indian Accounting Standards effective April 1, 2026. The implementation of Ind AS will be applicable to all categories of insurers - life, general, stand alone health insurers and reinsurers. The amendment sets out the regulatory framework governing the recognition, measurement, presentation and disclosure of financial statements under Ind AS. Introduction of Ind AS aims to enhance consistency, transparency and comparability in financial reporting across the insurance sector, in alignment with globally accepted standards, IRDAI said on Monday, announcing approval for the Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority of India (Actuarial, Finance and Investment Functions of Insurers) (Amendment) Regulations, 2026.

Mukesh Ambani's entertainment venture JioStar has terminated its broadcast deals in Bangladesh for the IPL cricket tournament, saying its local partner defaulted on payments, according to a document seen by *Reuters*. Bangladesh in January banned IPL broadcasts after one of the teams, Kolkata Knight Riders, dropped Bangladesh pacer Mustafizur Rahman on Indian cricket board's instruction, just as tensions rose between the two countries following the killing of a Hindu man in Bangladesh. Though Bangladesh is reviewing the ban and had on Saturday said any further steps will depend on the opinion of its sports ministry, the termination by JioStar means there will be no local broadcaster for the IPL season, even if the country were to change its stance. "The agreement stands terminated with immediate effect," JioStar said in a letter dated February 17 to Bangladesh broadcaster TSports, which had sublicensed the rights from JioStar for IPL seasons from 2023 to 2027.

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI



Ashwini Vaishnaw

Union Minister of Electronics and Information Technology Ashwini Vaishnaw on Monday castigated electronics industry players for not adopting the "six sigma" process in their businesses, something he had asked them to do during multiple interactions.

He was speaking at the launch of the fourth tranche of approvals under the Electronics Component Manufacturing Scheme (ECMS), which incentivises incremental pro-

duction of smaller components of electronic products. The ECMS is a ₹22,919-crore initiative that provides output and employment-based incentives to firms manufacturing a prescribed list of electronic components in India.

The Hindu Bureau
MUMBAI

Apartment sales in India's top nine cities continued to decline in Q1 CY 2026, falling below the 1 lakh unit mark after 18 quarters, owing to fewer supply across most major cities, a data analytics firm said.

According to NSE-listed real estate data analytics company PropEquity, housing sales fell by 13% YoY and 6% QoQ to 98,761 units, while launches fell by 19% YoY and 8% QoQ to 92,411 units in January-March 2026.

Bangaluru, with sales of 17,991 units, emerged as the highest selling market.

The city recorded 16% QoQ and 3% YoY growth.

Delhi-NCR with 12,141 units recorded 13% YoY growth.

However, on a QoQ basis, sales fell by 1%. In Mumbai, there has been a decline of 13% QoQ.

Samir Jasuja, Founder & CEO, Prop Equity said, "Housing sales continued to moderate in the first quarter of 2026 with Delhi-NCR and Bengaluru emerging as outliers."

"This reduction is on account of low supply across most cities. Close to 22,000 lesser units were supplied in Q1 2026 as compared to the same period last year," he said. "On the supply front, Delhi-NCR with 17,227 units launched in Q1, has come of age to emerge as the second biggest market."

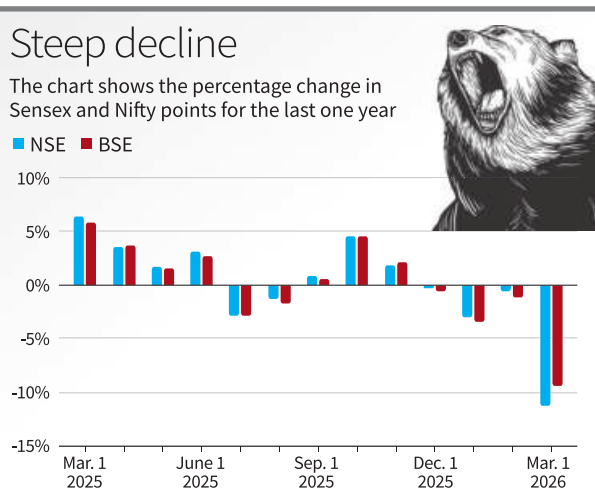
Index dips 2.14% on Monday; decline broad-based with 2,762 stocks declining and just 570 advancing from among the more than 3,000 stocks that traded in the National Stock Exchange

Ashokamithran T.
MUMBAI

Indian investors faced their worst March in six years as benchmark Nifty fell 11.36%, its steepest decline since March 2020, as global markets reel under the war between the U.S. and Iran. Nifty fell 2.14% to 22,331.4 points on Monday, extending the six weeks of continuous declines. Sensex fell 2.22% to 71,947.5 points.

Both Nifty and Sensex opened at 22,549.65 points and 72,565.22 points respectively, down over 1% from the previous close. After gaining a few points on the way down to the day's high, the benchmark indices tumbled down to the day's close.

The decline was broad-



based with 2,762 stocks down and just 570 advancing from the over 3,000 stocks that traded in the National Stock Exchange (NSE).

There were just 13 months since 1995, when monthly returns declined by 10% or more, and four of them were in 2008. The worst monthly decline recorded was in October 2008, when Nifty crashed by over 26%.

All the 21 sectoral Nifty indices dipped, with Nifty PSU Bank dropping by

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman on Monday defended the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code (IBC) in Parliament, citing the high level of realisations from distressed assets, recovery for creditors, and turnaround of companies that have emerged from the resolution process.

Replying to the debate on the Insolvency and Bankruptcy (Amendment)

Bill 2026, Ms. Sitharaman said the point of the IBC was not debt recovery, but the rescue of viable businesses and addressing their financial stress.

"The IBC is a framework for rescuing viable businesses and resolving financial stress while preserving the enterprise value," Ms. Sitharaman said. "It was never intended to be a debt-recovery tool. Recovery values are a by-product," she added.

She said, the IBC process is market-driven and recoveries reflect the underlying asset quality and commercial viability of the distressed enterprise.

"The IBC actually realises 94.95% of the fair value of the company at the time of admission," she said.

The Lok Sabha passed the Bill to amend the insolvency law to provide for strict timelines, an out-of-court settlement option and enable the framework for cross-border insolvency processes.

Reuters
NEW DELHI

India's fiscal deficit in April-February was ₹12.5 trillion (\$132 billion) or 80.4% of the estimate for the financial year ending March 31, government data showed on Monday.

Net tax receipts stood at ₹21.5 trillion, an increase from ₹20.2 trillion collected in the same period a year ago.

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Even as the rupee closed at ₹94.8 a dollar on Monday after depreciating to an all time low of over ₹95 earlier in the day, Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman said that the rupee was “going fine” against the U.S. dollar compared with other emerging market currencies.

The rupee depreciated by more than ₹3 since March 2, 2026, when the pair was trading over ₹91. The Indian currency has depreciated by 4.1% since the commencement of the West Asia conflict on February 28, 2026, crossing ₹95 for the first time on Monday.

With oil prices remaining sticky at over \$104 a barrel and foreign institutional investors (FIIs) continuing to sell Indian stocks causing dollar outflow on Monday, the rupee's value plunged to an all time low.

The Reserve Bank of India capped net open positions that banks can hold in the onshore currency market at \$100 million for banks at the end of the day.

The limit was up to 25% of the bank's capital and

was intended to arrest speculation in the market. While the central bank's move did yield some re-

sults with the rupee opening at ₹93 on Monday, weak equity markets leading to FII exit and still high oil prices led to further depreciation. The issue of rupee depreciation was also

raised by Opposition members in the Lok Sabha but Ms. Sitharaman asserted that India's economic fundamentals remain strong.

“India’s economy is strong, our fiscal situation is strong, and the entire world is praising our fiscal deficit management. Our forex reserves are solid,” the Finance Minister said, adding, “Compared to other emerging economies, the rupee is doing fine (*theek chal raha hain*)..absolutely going fine”.

Ms. Sitharaman intervened after Samajwadi Party member Dharmendra Yadav referred to Prime Minister Narendra Modi's earlier statement, made as the Chief Minister of Gujarat, in which Mr. Modi had claimed falling value of rupee eroded the then Prime Minister Manmohan Singh's reputation.

"Now, I want to ask whether the Prime Minister's reputation has been affected or not," Mr. Yadav asked. The Finance Minister then responded by saying that Mr. Modi emerged on top at a recent survey of world leaders.

She said the BJP was worried about rupee's falling value as India was considered one of the "fragile five" economies under the UPA. She also targeted the Opposition for trying to pull down the country.

In a written reply, Ms. Sitharaman said the depreciation was not specific to the Indian currency, noting that several major Asian currencies had also weakened against the dollar during the period.

	GREATER VISAKHAPATNAM MUNICIPAL CORPORATION	
ELECTRICAL DIVISION - Request for Proposal (RFP)		
RFP tender notice No.02/2025-26/SE(Elec)/EE(Elec), Dt. 28.03.2026 Number of works: 1 No. Tender downloading Starting Dt.: 28.03.2026 , Closing Dt.: 16.04.2026 Note: Further details at http://www.tenderapeprocurement.gov.in EE (Electrical) Cell No. 9912349441 SE (Electrical) Cell No. 8187899217		
		For Commissioner


AMARAVATI GROWTH AND INFRASTRUCTURE CORPORATION LTD.
 Project Office, Rayapudi, Amaravati, Guntur Dist., AP-522237.

EMPLOYMENT NOTIFICATION No.5/2026, Dt. 30.03.2026

Notification is hereby issued for engagement of services in AGIL, Amaravati on Deputation/ Contract basis. Online application is available in the AGIL & APCRDA websites in careers tab and can be submitted from **31.03.2026 to 14.04.2026**. For further details pls visit <https://agil.org> & <https://crda.ap.gov.in>.

S.No.	Name of the post	No's of Posts
1	Chief Engineer (Electrical)	1
2	Superintending Engineer (Electrical)	1
3	Executive Engineer (Electrical)	2
4	Executive Engineer (Mechanical)	1

Sd/- Managing Director, AGIL, Amaravati

NAGPUR METROPOLITAN REGION DEVELOPMENT AUTHORITY

Station Road, Kingsway, Sadar, Nagpur-440001.

e-TENDER NOTICE No. 41/2025-26

www.mahatenders.gov.in

Sealed Percentage rate/ Item rate e-tenders are invited from Non-Registered /Registered Contractors with N.M.R.D.A./ N.I.T./P.W.D./ N.M.C. or other Govt. Dept. as per eligibility criteria for **One** work. The details of works will be uploaded on tender website i.e. www.mahatenders.gov.in

Sr. No.	Name of Work	Amount of Work / E.M.D. in Rs.	Eligibility/Tender Cost in Rs.	Time Limit in Months	Division
1	Appointment of Consultant for "Providing Comprehensive Architectural & Engineering Consultancy Services including Masterplan, Internal Infrastructure, External Development & Landscape, Detailed Project Report on the Sustainable Model etc. for Development of Naveen Nagpur on 1710 Acres Land." (Hind Call)	As per Tender Document 10,00,000/-	As per Tender Document 29,500/-	36	Town Planning

Money :- E.M.D. is to be paid by online only. **Plans & Estimates** :- Available in the Technical Section, Head Office, Sadar, Nagpur. **Tender Forms** :- From **02.00 P.M.** on Date **01.04.2026** up to **2.00 P.M.** on Date **08.04.2026** on www.mahatenders.gov.in **Receipt / Submission** :- From **02.00 P.M.** on Date **01.04.2026** up to **2.00 P.M.** on Date **08.04.2026** on www.mahatenders.gov.in. **Opening** :- At N.M.R.D.A. Office on Date **09.04.2026** at **2.00 P.M.** or as decided by N.M.R.D.A.

-sd- Superintending Engineer

Nagpur Metropolitan Region Development Authority

Advt. No. :- S.E/(NMRA)/94/2025-26 Dated :- 30.03.2026

NAGPUR METROPOLITAN REGION DEVELOPMENT AUTHORITY

Station Road, Kingsway, Sadar, Nagpur-440001.

e-TENDER NOTICE No. 40/2025-26

www.mahatenders.gov.in

Sealed Percentage rate/Item rate e-tenders are invited from Non-Registered /Registered Contractors with N.M.R.D.A./ N.I.T./P.W.D./ N.M.C. or other Govt. Dept. as per eligibility criteria for **One** work. The details of work will be uploaded on tender website i.e. www.mahatenders.gov.in

Sr.No.	Name of Work	Amount of Work / E.M.D. in Rs.	Eligibility/Tender Cost in Rs.	Time Limit in Months	Division
1	Request for Proposal for Appointment of Project Management Consultant (PMC) for World-class Redevelopment, Landscaping and Beautification of Deekshabhoomi, Nagpur. (IInd Call).	<u>As per Tender Document</u> 5,00,000/-	<u>As per Tender Document</u> 10,000/-	06	Project

Money :- E.M.D. is to be paid by online only. **Plans & Estimates** :- Available in the Technical Section, Head Office, Sadar, Nagpur. **Tender Forms** :- From **02.00 P.M.** on Date **01.04.2026** up to **2.00 P.M.** on Date **08.04.2026** on www.mahatenders.gov.in **Receipt / Submission** :- From **02.00 P.M.** on Date **01.04.2026** up to **2.00 P.M.** on Date **08.04.2026** on www.mahatenders.gov.in **Opening** :- At N.M.R.D.A. Office on Date **09.04.2026** at 2.00 P.M. or as decided by N.M.R.D.A.

-sd- Superintending Engineer

Advt. No. : S.E.(NM/RDA)/93/2025-26 Dated : 30.03.2026 Nagpur Metropolitan Region Development Authority

OFFICE OF THE SUPERINTENDING ENGINEER, P.W.D., CIRCLE-JHALAWAR							
Room No. - 15B, Ground Floor (Public Works Department), Mini Secretariat, Jhalawar							
E-mail - su.jhalawar@rediffmail.com / su.pwd@rajasthan.gov.in	Phone No. - 01432-230326						
S. No. - 1390	NIT No. 16/2025-26 Notice Inviting Bid NIR No. PWDS2526A6359						
Date :- 23.03.2026							
Bids for Construction of 08 Type-I Residence and Boundary Wall and Internal roads along with other essential infrastructure facilities at Jhalawar N.D. & भारतीय निगम सार पट्टीही होत आहे निधी सार आहे invited from interested bidders upto 6.00 PM, Dated 23.04.2026 Other particulars of the bid may be visited on the procurement portal (http://eproc.rajasthan.gov.in, http://tppp.raj.nic.in) of the Rajasthan and http://pwd.rajasthan.gov.in website. The approximate value of the procurement is Rs. 1030 Lacs.							
<table border="1" style="width: 100%; border-collapse: collapse;"> <tr> <th style="width: 50%;">S.No.</th> <th style="width: 50%;">UBN No.</th> </tr> <tr> <td>1</td> <td>PWDS2526W0826169</td> </tr> <tr> <td>2</td> <td>PWDS2526W0826170</td> </tr> </table>	S.No.	UBN No.	1	PWDS2526W0826169	2	PWDS2526W0826170	(Mukesh Chand Meena) Superintending Engineer Public Works Department Circle-Jhalawar
S.No.	UBN No.						
1	PWDS2526W0826169						
2	PWDS2526W0826170						
DIPRC/6079/2026							



AHMEDABAD MUNICIPAL CORPORATION

(ROAD PROJECT & ELECTRICAL DEPARTMENT)

E-TENDER NOTICE

ICONIC CITY SQUARE BUILDING PROJECT WORK

Sr. no.	Name of work	Estimated Tender Cost
1.	RFP for Construction, Maintenance and Operations (CMO) of Iconic City square building Project in Bodakdev Ward, North West Zone in AMC	Rs. 552,22,41,635.00 (Without GST)

Tender Downloading

Online submission up to

Details & tenders available on :

: Date: 10/04/2026

: Date: 25/05/2026 up to 18:00 hrs.

: www.tender.nprocure.com

Municipal Commissioner (AMC)

 CENTRAL ELECTRICITY REGULATORY COMMISSION 6th, 7th, & 8th Floor, Tower-B, World Trade Centre, Nauroji Nagar, New Delhi-110029	
Petition No. 32/TD/2026	Dated: 25.3.2026
NOTICE UNDER CLAUSE (a) OF SUB-SECTION (5) OF SECTION 15 OF THE ELECTRICITY ACT, 2003 (the Act)	
An application for the grant of a Category-V licence for inter-State trading in electricity across India has been made before the Commission by Energy Advisory Services Private Limited, WeWork Enam Sambhav, C-20, G Block Rd, G Block BKC, Bandra Kurla Complex, Bandra East, Mumbai - 400051. A copy of the application, along with its annexures and enclosures, made by the applicant for the grant of an inter-State trading licence to Energy Advisory Services Private Limited before the Commission can be accessed at the website www.easpl.co.in or inspected by any person in the Commission's office by following the laid down procedure. 3. On consideration of the material available on record, the Commission is satisfied that <i>prima facie</i> the applicant qualifies for the grant of a licence for inter-State trading in electricity and by order dated 25.3.2026, the Commission has proposed to grant a Category-V licence to the applicant for inter-State trading in electricity across India. 4. Notice is hereby given in pursuance of clause (a) of sub-section (5) of Section 15 of the Act to invite suggestions or objections, if any, to the proposal to grant the licence for inter-State trading in electricity as aforesaid by the Commission to be received by the undersigned latest by 14.4.2026 at the above noted address. The objections or suggestions received after the specified date shall not be considered. 5. The Commission has fixed the application for final disposal on 16.4.2026 and the person who files the suggestions or objections may in his discretion attend the hearing, for which no TA/DA shall be paid by the Commission.	
Sd/- (Harpreet Singh Pruthi) Secretary	

UN says two peacekeepers killed, some injured in southern Lebanon



Nepal's top court orders new govt. to justify arrest of former PM Oli



Rubio signals private talks, claims 'fractures' inside Islamic Republic



Iran's military claims Israel struck Kuwait plant; Indian worker killed



CM
Y
K



Through the noise, the results rang loud

A fiery passion and the refusal to back down, physically and mentally, defined Carolina Marin who hung up her racquet recently; perhaps feisty is how the Spaniard will be best remembered



I wish my career had ended in a different way but in life things don't always go as we want and we have to accept that

GETTY IMAGES

Devvanshi Bihani

She was already halfway there. A game up, leading in the second, moving with the same sharp intent that had once made her Olympic champion at the Rio 2016 Games. The semifinal at the Paris Olympics in 2024 was tilting her way, the crowd beginning to sense it too. That tightening grip she had on matches when she smelled the finish line.

And then, mid-rally, Carolina Marin stopped. She leapt for a shot on her backhand side, landed on her right foot, and the knee buckled.

The scream came instantly. Not the sharp, triumphant roar that had so often followed her winners, but something raw and involuntary. She collapsed to the court, clutching her knee, her face tightening in shock before the pain fully took over. The wheelchair came soon after, and so did the tears.

It turned out to be her final match as a professional. “I would have liked for us to see each other one last time on court, but I don’t want to put my body at risk for that,” she said while announcing her retirement. “I wish my career had ended in a different way but in life things don’t always go as we want and we have to accept that,” she added.

That moment in Paris was not an aberration. It was, in many ways, the most honest snapshot of Carolina’s career. She had always played on the edge. There was no measured version of her game. Subtlety was never her game, and for many, that made her hard to like. In her red sleeveless outfit, she wore her emotions on her sleeve and let the world hear them: She shouted, celebrated and let every point show on her face. Wins brought wide, unfiltered smiles on the podium. Losses and setbacks brought tears just as openly. Nothing was held back. The screams, the urgency between points, the refusal to slow down even for a second – unless the cluster of pins holding her hair tight into a bun called for a conveniently timed adjustment – unsettled opponents and, at times, irritated audiences.

There were enough reasons for people to root against her. But to stop there was to miss the point. Because beneath the noise was a player of rare clarity. She played to win, or not at all! Every rally was chased, every point claimed, every match attacked as if it might slip away if she loosened her grip even slightly. It was what made her the Golden Quartet (Olympic, World Championships, Continent Games, and Continental Championships), as the voice of badminton Gill Clark wrote in her tribute

to Carolina. And that was the thing about Carolina. You could dislike the sound. You could question the manner. But past all of it, the results were undeniable.

The breakthrough

At the 2014 World championships in Copenhagen, a 21-year-old from Spain walked into a field dominated by the sport’s most established names and left with the title. On her way, Carolina beat players who defined different generations of the game. She got past Japan’s Minatsu Mitani, then outplayed China’s Wang Yihan, one of the most consistent forces in women’s badminton. In the final, she came from behind to defeat Olympic champion Li Xuerui.

Spain, until then, had no real presence in badminton at this level. The sport’s champions emerged from systems far removed from where Carolina had grown up. No one except Coach Fernando Rivas expected Huelva to produce a world champion.

Coach Rivas first met Carolina, a trained flamenco dancer, as a 13-year-old. He saw a competitor. A teenager who refused to give up on rallies. What struck him was her speed, her instinct to attack, and a command over the tempo of the game. The rest, he believed, could be built. With the right structure, he believed, she could be turned into a champion. And that belief, more than anything else at the time, set the course.

There were players Carolina could not initially solve. Among them was Saina Nehwal, one of the few who was not affected by Carolina’s screams. Where others were unsettled, she answered back in the same vein. For a period, Saina had the edge in their head-to-head. Rivas later admitted that “Saina made me a much better coach than I ever was.”

At the 2015 World Championships in Jakarta, the Spaniard defeated Saina in the final to retain her title, a result that felt like a measure of revenge after earlier losses. It also came just months after Carolina had beaten Saina at the All England Championships. Then they met frequently in 2019, with Carolina winning the 2019 Malaysia Masters semifinal, but Saina winning the 2019 Indonesia Masters final after Carolina retired injured. Their last professional meeting was in 2020, with Carolina leading 7-6.

Peak: Rio, and the rival

If Rio 2016 was the summit of the Spaniard’s career, then P.V. Sindhu was the opponent who gave that peak its shape.

They had crossed paths before, even as teenagers, but the Olympic final laid the foundation for what would grow into a

defining rivalry.

Carolina came into the 2016 Rio Olympics as the reigning World champion, already with two titles (2014 and 2015) and an All England crown earlier that year. She had built a game around speed and suffocation. Sindhu, 21 then, arrived as the underdog. Tall, composed, willing to stretch rallies instead of rushing them.

For a brief moment, it looked like Sindhu had cracked the code. She took the opening game. She absorbed the pace, redirected it, and forced Carolina into longer exchanges. And then Carolina did what defined her career. She raised the tempo, shortened rallies, and attacked relentlessly at the net.

When it ended, Carolina dropped to the court, face down, arms tucked under her, as if holding the moment in place. Olympic champion! The 24-year-old became the first non-Asian woman to win gold in women’s singles, breaking a hold that had defined the sport for decades.

But what comes after you have already reached the top?

In the months that followed, the high gave way to a strange emptiness. She and her coach had achieved the dream they had chased for years. Later she talked about phases where motivation dipped, results dried up, and doubt crept in. At times, she feared she might not win another big title. It took long conversations with her team, work with a psychologist, and a willingness to change before the belief slowly returned.

The results returned with conviction when Carolina won the European championships again in 2018. She began to look like a player in control of her game and mind at the World Championships in Nanjing, where she defeated Sindhu again in the final to claim her third world title.

Fall and fight

But just as her mind found the way back, her body began to give way...

In January 2019, at the Indonesia Masters, Carolina went down mid-match in the final against Saina. What initially seemed like a bad fall turned out to be far more serious: a torn ACL in her right knee. It was the first major injury of her career at the very top.

She spent the next eight months away from the court. When she returned in September, at the China Open, she fought through the draw and, in the final, defeated World No. 1 Tai Tzu-ying in three games, overturning a first-game deficit.

In 2021 when the circuit resumed after the pandemic interruption, she started the year with back-to-back Super 1000 titles in Thailand, defeating Tzu-ying in both finals. She also reclaimed the

European Championships, a title that had begun to feel almost hers by default, whenever she showed up.

She looked every bit like a contender with the Tokyo Olympics approaching.

And then, just weeks before the Games, it happened again. During a training session, her knee gave way, another ACL tear, this time in the left. She withdrew before the tournament started.

She spent close to a year away from the circuit once more. When she returned in May 2022 at the European Championships, it was déjà vu, another comeback marked the same way as before. She won the title again, as if to insist that even repeated setbacks had not dulled the edge that had always defined her. She also reached the final of the French Open, falling narrowly, but showing she could still go deep in the biggest tournaments.

In 2023, she reached the World championships final, beating top players such as Tzu-ying and Akane Yamaguchi along the way, before losing the gold-medal contest to the rampant An Se-young. By the end of the year, she had climbed back into the world’s top five, a reminder that she was not done yet.

In 2024, she won the All England title again, nine years after her first, added another European crown, and returned to the world’s top three.

At 31, she reached the semifinals of the Paris Olympics, becoming the second oldest player in the draw to go that far. Against He Bingjiao, she took the opening game and was leading in the second, the match tilting her way once more. Then, off a heavy landing from an overhead, it happened again.

She tried to continue, returning to court with a knee brace and playing a couple more points before being forced to retire due to limited movement. The injury also ruled her out of the bronze-medal match against Gregoria Mariska Tunjung.

“Deep down, I did retire on court in Paris in 2024 (Olympics). We just didn’t know it at the time,” Carolina said in her retirement announcement.

THE GIST

- Marin broke into an Asian-dominated sport, winning the World championships in 2014, '15 and '18 and going on to become Olympic champion at Rio 2016
- Injuries, including multiple ACL tears, interrupted her career, but she repeatedly returned to the top, adding titles and staying among the elite
- Marin’s career came to an end in Paris 2024 when an on-court injury brought an abrupt end to a journey defined by playing on the edge



A night photograph showing a city skyline across a body of water. A prominent, bright, curved light trail, likely from a satellite or aircraft, arcs across the upper portion of the sky. The city lights are visible along the horizon, and the water in the foreground is dark.

The Falcon 9 upper stage re-entering the atmosphere above Berlin on February 19, 2025.
AFP

Falcon 9 reentry pollutes upper atmosphere

Vasudevan Mukunth

The world is in the throes of a second Space Age, with space-based data and assets being increasingly integrated into terrestrial activities – from helping cars and ships find their way to predicting impending disasters. For this, various countries have launched thousands of satellites to orbit, with orders of magnitude more poised to launch in the coming years.

While this proliferation has raised concerns about orbital debris, scientists are increasingly also concerned about a different kind of fallout: the chemical pollution left behind when these objects burn up in the atmosphere.

Now, for the first time, researchers from Germany, Peru, and the U.K. have tracked a plume of metal vapour created by a Falcon 9 rocket reentering the atmosphere. Their findings, published in *Communications Earth & Environment*, confirm that space traffic is actively altering the chemistry of the atmosphere's uppermost reaches.

The study was driven by the rise of

Researchers tracked metal vapour created by a Falcon 9 rocket reentering the atmosphere and their findings confirmed that space traffic is altering the chemistry of the atmosphere

mega-constellations like Starlink, as part of which thousands of satellites are designed to de-orbit and burn up at the end of their five-year lifespans. When they do, they inject metals like aluminum and lithium into the mesosphere and lower thermosphere (MLT).

Scientists are concerned that this pollution could harm the ozone layer and change how the atmosphere traps heat.

On February 19, 2025, when the upper stage of a SpaceX Falcon 9 rocket made an uncontrolled re-entry over Europe, the researchers used a resonance lidar located in Kühlungsborn in Germany. The instrument fired a laser into the sky to measure the density of specific atoms nearly 100 km up.

To prove the connection to the rocket, the researchers combined a sophisticated atmospheric model with wind data from local meteor radars and they calculated backwards trajectories. This allowed them to trace the movement of air masses from the observation point in Germany back to the exact time and location where the rocket disintegrated. About 20 hours after the reentry, the lidar detected a surge in the number of lithium atoms at an altitude of 96 km – a concentration 10 times higher than natural levels.

Natural space dust, like that shed by meteors, contains very little lithium. In fact, the entire earth usually receives only about 80 g of natural lithium from space dust per day. But modern rockets and satellites use lithium-aluminum alloys for their hulls and lithium-ion batteries for power; a single Falcon 9 stage contains roughly 30 km of the metal.

The team's models showed the air mass had drifted 1,600 km from the west coast of Ireland, over which the rocket reentered, to the skies over Northern Germany. The team also checked for natural explanations such as geomagnetic storms and ionospheric interference.

As the mass of human-made objects re-entering the atmosphere begins to rival the mass of natural meteors, the ability to identify and track pollutants coming from the skies will be important. “The upper atmosphere, as the first part of the earth’s environment impacted by re-entry, offers a valuable opportunity to observe ablated materials close to their source, before they undergo chemical transformation and atmospheric dispersion,” the researchers wrote in their paper.

For feedback and suggestions
for 'Science', please write to
science@thehindu.co.in with the
subject 'Daily page'

THE SCIENCE QUIZ

75 years of the UNIVAC I computer

Vasudevan Mukunth

QUESTION 1

While the UNIVAC I is often cited as the first commercial computer, the British _____ Mark I, named for the firm that made it, was delivered to Manchester University in February 1951, a few weeks earlier. Fill in the blank

QUESTION 2

Before UNIVAC I, engineers would process data using _____ in a labour-intensive process. The UNIVAC I introduced the UNISERVO tape drive, which used a metal tape half around 1.2 cm wide that allowed the computer to read data at 12,800 characters per second — a large leap in efficiency. Fill in the blanks.

QUESTION 3

UNIVAC I's designers Presper Eckert and John Mauchly also built X, the world's first programmable electronic digital computer, whose first problem was the feasibility of a hydrogen bomb. X was completed in 1945 and operated for a decade. Name X.

QUESTION 4

Whereas modern computers use silicon chips for RAM, the UNIVAC I used a technology called delay lines. The machine stored data as sound pulses travelling through tanks of liquid Y. Its designers picked Y because sound had a high speed in it (1,450 m/s) and transmitted acoustic signals efficiently. Name Y.

QUESTION 5

The UNIVAC I was a first-generation computer powered by roughly 5,200

vacuum tubes. The history of modern computing has essentially been the history of replacing these tubes — first with transistors in the late 1950s, then Z in the 1960s, and finally the microprocessor in 1971. Name Z.

Answers to March 26 quiz:

1. Single-word term for a species' local extinction – **Ans: Extirpation**

2. When a species evolves so much as to renew itself. **Ans: Anagenesis**

3. Forms of extinction related to

population size and effects on ecosystems – **Ans: Functional and ecological**

4. Population threshold under which a species is 'living dead' – **Ans:**

Minimum viable population

3. What a species has when it is owed to extinction – **Ans: Extinction debt**

Visual: Coelacanth
First contact: Prem Nath Tiwari | Tama

Biswas | K.N. Viswanathan | Anmol Agrawal

A portrait of a man in a U.S. Navy uniform. He is wearing a dark blue jacket with a white shirt and a dark tie. He has a name tag that reads "WILLIAM J. HARRIS". He is wearing a dark blue cap with a white band and a gold eagle emblem. He is also wearing glasses. The background is a light blue wall with a portion of the American flag visible on the left.

VISUAL: Name this woman.

She worked on UNIVAC I at Remington Rand, where she developed the foundation for COBOL, a programming language that still runs much of the world's banking infrastructure. PUBLIC DOMAIN

Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Percentage of candidates with criminal cases

23 in per cent. About 23% of candidates contesting the Puducherry Assembly elections have declared criminal cases, according to a report by the Association for Democratic Reforms. The analysis also found that 13% face serious charges. PTI

Attacks, misconduct cases against govt. officials in Odisha

1,399 incidents. Odisha reported 1,399 cases of attacks and misbehaviour against government officials over the past two years, Chief Minister Mohan Charan Majhi informed the Assembly. PTI

Israel's approved Defence Budget in 2026

142 in Israeli shekel billion. Israel's parliament approved the 2026 budget early on Monday, providing for a significant increase in military spending as the country remains engaged in wars on multiple fronts. AFP

Police station heads transferred by EC across West Bengal

173 The Election Commission on Sunday transferred officers-in-charge and inspectors-in-charge of 173 police stations across West Bengal, including 31 under Kolkata Police, as part of measures to ensure fair Assembly polls, officials said. PTI

Number of days ATF supplies will be available

60 There is an adequate supply of Aviation Turbine Fuel (ATF) for the next 60 days in the country without any interruption, Minister of Civil Aviation Kinjarapu Rammohan Naidu said. PTI
COMPILED BY THE HINDU DATA TEAM

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On the implications of euthanasia

The Supreme Court reaffirmed the right to die with dignity under Article 21, allowing withdrawal of life support and emphasising patient autonomy; it shows a shift towards dignity and relief from suffering, while raising concerns about misuse and social inequality

LETTER & SPIRIT

C.B.P. Srivastava

The recent judgment by the Supreme Court in the *Harish Rana v. Union of India* (2026) case has raised questions regarding the ethical, legal, and social implications (ELSI) of passive euthanasia. Euthanasia is related to the right to die with dignity, which was recognised by the Supreme Court in *Common Cause v. Union of India* (2018). The court held that the right to die with dignity is inseparable from the right to receive quality palliative care. Hence, in the Harish Rana case, the court, for the first time, allowed the withdrawal of the applicant's Clinically Assisted Nutrition and Hydration (CANH).

The court had held in the *Common Cause* case that the right to die with dignity is an integral part of the right to life under Article 21 of the Constitution. Allowing passive euthanasia and recognising the Advance Medical Directives (living wills) for terminally ill patients to refuse life-prolonging treatment was laid down in *Aruna Shanbaug v. Union of India* (2011). Following this, in *Common Cause v. Union of India* (2023), the court streamlined the process of passive euthanasia, making its implementation easier.

In the new guidelines, the court changed the requirement for two medical boards, a hospital board and a district-level board, refining it to make the process smoother, and mandatory immediate judicial oversight in every case was removed. While addressing advance directives (living wills), the court emphasised patient autonomy, allowing individuals to refuse life-sustaining treatment and die naturally with dignity.

Considering the above, a few questions arise regarding euthanasia and its relevance in India. First, whether granting



GETTY IMAGES

passive euthanasia is ethical. It is logically perceived that birth and death are natural processes; hence, nature should decide when a person dies and how the body responds to illness. In this context, any interference with the rules of nature may be considered unethical.

However, it is also a fact that life is the period between birth and death, and it is spent in a society where dignity is of utmost importance. Life, therefore, can be viewed as more sociological than biological. Both the birth and the death should be dignified. In this context, the right to die with dignity assumes greater significance.

Ethical aspects of euthanasia

The ethical principles enshrined in this act of granting passive euthanasia further clarify this issue. The primary and probably the most significant aspect is the principle of autonomy, which grants the patient – or, in cases of terminal illness, their next of kin – the right to make

decisions. Second is the principle of beneficence, which is related to the patient's benefit, which the doctors treating the patient should consider. Third is the principle of non-maleficence, which suggests that the decision to allow passive euthanasia should not cause harm. Finally, the principle of justice must be protected to ensure that no injustice is done to the patient.

Apart from these principles, we may look at the decision from the viewpoint of the Theory of Double Effect proposed by St. Thomas Aquinas. According to this theory, every action creates two effects, and the one that is less harmful or beneficial should be considered ethical. In the case of passive euthanasia, the action – withdrawal of life support, or CANH in the Harish Rana case – leads to two effects. First, the death of the patient, and second, relief from suffering. If the decision is taken without malice, the act can be considered ethical as the patient was relieved of his pain.

Social implications

The right to die with dignity or passive euthanasia in India reflects a progressive but cautious approach, mainly due to a transition in societal values. This transition is from rigid moral traditions to a more compassionate, rights-based approach. While it promotes dignity, autonomy, and relief from suffering, it also raises concerns about misuse, ethical conflicts, and social inequality. There has also been a transition from the social attitude of protecting life at any cost to the quality of life being more important than its length.

Another major implication is economic in nature, as long-term life-support treatment without any hope of recovery would put the family under severe economic stress, especially in the middle- and lower-income groups. In this context, the right to die with dignity appears to be justified.

Further, social implications may include its possible misuse and especially vulnerable people like the elderly, disabled and poor may face coercion. This may create a situation where the decision may be driven by financial constraints, social neglect, and family pressure. Hence, critics may point out that it would amount to disguised abandonment.

The court has taken utmost care while delivering the judgment and stated that “passive euthanasia is an obsolete and incorrect term, and should not be used either in common usage or legal writing and discussions”. It unnecessarily confuses the legal position on the issue, as the debate cannot be neatly divided into ‘acts’ and ‘omissions’. Further, the court also held that the patient is not abandoned by withdrawing or withholding medical treatment. Palliative and end-of-life care must continue for these patients.

(C.B.P. Srivastava is President, Centre for Applied Research in Governance, Delhi)

THE GIST

▼ The right to die with dignity is inseparable from the right to receive quality palliative care, and the court allowed the withdrawal of Clinically Assisted Nutrition and Hydration for the first time.

▼ The revised guidelines streamlined the process by modifying the requirement of multiple medical boards and removing mandatory immediate judicial oversight, making implementation smoother.

What the Meta-YouTube ruling means for social media

What did the jury hold the platforms liable for? How did the case focus on platform design over content?

Saeed Pande

The story so far:

A Los Angeles Superior Court jury, on March 25, found Meta Platforms and Alphabet's YouTube liable for designing platforms in ways that foster addiction and harm users' mental health. The case centred on a woman who was addicted to social media platforms. The jury awarded \$3 million in compensatory damages, which dispensed 70% to Meta and 30% to YouTube, and designated punitive damages of up to \$3 million, subject to judicial confirmation.

What did the verdict say?

The presiding judge at the Los Angeles Superior Court has yet to formalise the final judgment. The 20-year-old woman, known as Kaley, testified that her social media use began as early as age 6 on YouTube and age 9 on Instagram because of their attention-grabbing design.

Kaley's lawyers argued that features like infinite scroll, autoplay, and algorithm-driven notifications were specifically engineered to “hook” young users. She testified that this addiction

exacerbated her depression, anxiety, and body dysmorphia.

The case focused on platform design rather than content, sidestepping Section 230 immunity by characterising social media platforms as “defective products,” focusing on design elements such as algorithmic amplification and addictive features rather than third-party content, making it harder for the companies to avert liability.

Snapchat and TikTok were defendants in the trial, while both settled with the plaintiff before it began; the terms of the agreements were not disclosed.

What evidence swayed the jury?

The case reportedly relied on internal corporate documents, expert testimony, and user-behaviour data, pointing to evidence such as the ‘Facebook Files’, internal research reported by *The Wall Street Journal* in 2021 showing Meta knew Instagram could worsen body image issues for teenage girls, with one study noting that “32% of teen girls said Instagram made them feel worse.” They also cited findings referenced in U.S. Senate hearings, where whistleblower Frances Haugen testified that company

research linked platform design to anxiety and compulsive use.

In YouTube's case, it pointed to concerns that its recommendation system steers users toward increasingly engaging content to maximise watch time, an issue noted in academic research and media reports.

Why is this verdict a landmark?

The ruling is significant because it shifts liability from content to platform design. It challenges protections under Section 230 of the U.S. Communications Decency Act, long used to shield firms from responsibility for user-generated content. Courts have typically dismissed such cases under Section 230 protections. For instance, in *Gonzalez v. Google* (2023), the U.S. Supreme Court declined to hold Google liable for YouTube's algorithmic recommendations of ISIS-related content. Similarly, in *Twitter v. Taamneh* (2023), claims against Twitter, Facebook, and Google for aiding terrorism were rejected due to insufficient proof of direct liability. These rulings reinforced that platforms are generally not responsible for third-party content, even when amplified by algorithms.

What changes for social media companies?

The verdict came a day after a jury in New Mexico found Meta liable for the way in which its platforms endangered children and exposed them to sexually explicit material and contact with sexual predators. If upheld, the verdict could compel platforms to rethink core design features. The ruling heightens demands for algorithmic transparency, as seen in proposals like the U.S. Algorithmic Accountability Act. Crucially, the risk of punitive damages and over 1,600 pending lawsuits could trigger costly, copycat litigation, making aggressive engagement-driven design legally vulnerable.

What is next for regulation?

At least half of American teens use YouTube or Instagram daily, according to the Pew Research Center. California is considering stricter rules on teen social media use, including potential restrictions on addictive features. At the federal level, lawmakers have proposed bills mandating algorithmic transparency and stronger child-safety protections.

Recently, countries such as Australia have imposed restrictions on children to stop or limit their use of social media. The U.K. is running a pilot programme to see how a ban on social media for people aged under 16 may work. If upheld on appeal, it could mark the beginning of a new era in which algorithmic design is scrutinised not just for efficiency, but for its societal and psychological impact.

(Saeed Pande is a freelance writer with a focus on politics, current affairs, international relations, and geopolitics)

THE GIST

▼ A Los Angeles jury found Meta and YouTube liable for platform design that fostered addiction and harmed mental health, shifting focus from content to algorithmic amplification and addictive features.

▼ The ruling challenges Section 230 protections and could trigger costly litigation, regulatory scrutiny, and changes to engagement-driven design.

